

A Fine Balance



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF ROHINTON MISTRY

Rohinton Mistry was born into a Parsi family in Mumbai, India (then called Bombay). He lived there for several years, obtaining a degree in mathematics before eventually moving to Canada in 1975 with his wife. In Toronto, he worked as a bank clerk and studied English and philosophy part-time at the University of Toronto, completing his degree in 1982. Starting in 1983, he began writing and achieving recognition for his short stories, which often focused on life among Parsi Indians in Mumbai. His first novel, *Such a Long Journey*, came out in 1991, winning several awards and being translated into several languages. His second novel, *A Fine Balance*, was even more successful and is arguably his best-known work. Mistry currently lives in Ontario, Canada.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Although most of the characters in *A Fine Balance* are fictional, almost all of the historical events that appear in the novel have some basis in the real history of India. One character who *isn't* entirely fictional is the Prime Minister: although she is never named, she seems to be based on Indira Gandhi, the real-life prime minister of India during the mid-20th century. Indira Gandhi had no direct blood relation to the famous Mahatma Gandhi, although her father, Jawaharlal Nehru was perhaps the most significant figure next to Mahatma Gandhi in the Indian Independence Movement from Britain. British rule in India was unpopular due to the exploitative and often violent relationship that British colonists had with the people of India. The second-longest-serving prime minister in Indian history, Indira Gandhi was influential but controversial. Many of the government policies that appear in the novel—including the allegations of fixing elections, the Emergency, the arrest of political opponents, the programs of forced sterilization, and the demolition of slums—all have a basis in real events that happened in India in the 1970s. Additionally, like the Prime Minister in the novel, Indira Gandhi was assassinated in 1984, and this led to widespread violence across the country against Sikhs (a religious minority), due to the fact that Gandhi's assassins were her Sikh bodyguards.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

Rohinton Mistry's fiction is part of a broad literary movement called postcolonialism, which focuses on works by or about people from countries that used to be colonies. This includes India and the much of South Asia, as well as other former colonies from around the world. One of the most noteworthy

figures in defining and popularizing the concept of postcolonialism was the Palestinian American literary critic Edward Said (*Orientalism*). Some of most popular postcolonial writers who have written novels set in India include Anita Desai (*The Clear Light of Day*), Amitav Ghosh ([The Shadow Lines](#)), Salman Rushdie ([Midnight's Children](#)), and Arundhati Roy ([The God of Small Things](#)). Rohinton Mistry also occasionally makes references to older Indian texts, including the *Ramayana*, whose traditional author, Valmiki, inspired the name for the character Mr. Valmik. Texts like the *Ramayana* were originally transmitted orally until eventually being written down in Sanskrit. These texts remain an important part of some Indian religions today, including Hinduism and Buddhism, and they are a primary source of information about Hindu deities, including Krishna, who is mentioned briefly in the novel. Mistry also took inspiration from European authors, perhaps most notably Charles Dickens ([Great Expectations](#)), who also wrote sprawling novels about characters attempting to survive in urban poverty.

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** A Fine Balance
- **When Written:** 1991–1995
- **Where Written:** Ontario, Canada
- **When Published:** 1995
- **Literary Period:** Postcolonialism
- **Genre:** Novel, Historical Fiction
- **Setting:** India
- **Climax:** Maneck comes back to see Dina, Omprakash, and Ishvar.
- **Antagonist:** Oppression, Poverty, Corruption
- **Point of View:** Third Person Omniscient

EXTRA CREDIT

Three for Three. Although Mistry has released only three novels, each has received high acclaim, including making the shortlist for the prestigious Booker Prize.

Such a Long Journey. Although Mistry isn't Muslim, in 2002, he canceled his U.S. book tour for *Family Matters* due to the racial profiling that he and his wife experienced at an airport in the wake of the September 11th terrorist attacks.



PLOT SUMMARY

Ishvar and his nephew Omprakash, both lower-class Indian men from the Chamaar caste, are traveling on a train to a big

city, where they have been hired to work as tailors. On the train, they meet a student named Maneck, and they learn that they're all headed to the same place: Maneck is renting a room from Dina, the woman who has hired Ishvar and Omprakash to work for her. The men's journey is happening during a time of social upheaval, a couple decades after India gained independence from Britain, when the Prime Minister has declared the nation to be in a state of crisis known as the Emergency.

Ishvar grew up in a small village where he left with his brother, Narayan, to learn how to be a tailor from a Muslim man named Ashraf. But when Narayan challenged a powerful upper-caste villager named Thakur Dharamsi who oversaw voting in the area, Thakur Dharamsi killed Narayan and much of his family, leaving just Ishvar and Omprakash as survivors who have to find their own way in the world.

Meanwhile, Maneck came from a wealthier background, but his father, Farokh's, successful soda business has struggled to compete in a modern industrialized India. Farokh sent Maneck away to be educated in a new trade, but aside from a friend named Avinash that he plays chess with, Maneck struggled to fit in with the other boys at college.

Dina also grew up in a relatively comfortable background, with a father, Dr. Shroff, who devoted long hours at his job to helping other people. Dina fell in love with and married a man named Rustom, but after three happy years of marriage, he was killed in a bicycling accident while going to the store to pick up ice cream.

Now, circumstances have brought Ishvar, Omprakash, Maneck, and Dina together. Dina needs money to keep paying for her house and not have to move back in with her strict brother, Nusswan. The dresses that Ishvar and Omprakash sew for Dina help to provide both her and them with income. The money that Dina receives from hosting Maneck as a renter also helps her stay independent. In her free time, Dina makes a **quilt** out of old scraps of material from various sources.

Ishvar and Omprakash struggle to adapt to life in the big city. The hut that they live in gets demolished during a slum "beautification" that police Sergeant Kesar leads. At one point, trucks come to round up the people in the slum, and Ishvar and Omprakash end up working for a while as unpaid laborers on an irrigation project. They manage to make it out of the camp with the help of a man called Beggarmaster who protects local beggars but takes a cut of their earnings and sometimes disfigures infants in order to make them better beggars.

When Ishvar and Omprakash make it back to the city, Dina eventually lets them spend the evenings on her verandah. Although her rent collector, Ibrahim, threatens to evict her on behalf of the landlord for running an illegal business out of her home, Beggarmaster offers to protect Dina and keeps away the goondas who try to intimidate her.

Ishvar, Omprakash, Maneck, and Dina all begin to make meals together and eat at the same table, despite Dina's initial resistance. Dina comes to enjoy having so many people in her home. Ishvar and Omprakash make plans to get Omprakash married and bring his new wife back to Dina's house. Meanwhile, Maneck plans to go to college for another three years and continue to stay with Dina.

But when Ishvar and Omprakash go back to their home village to try to find a wife for Omprakash, police round them up and truck them off to one of the sterilization camps that have been popping up around the country. The doctors at the camp force Omprakash and Ishvar to get vasectomies with unsterilized equipment. When Thakur Dharamsi sees Omprakash, he orders for him to be castrated as well. By the time Ishvar and Omprakash make it back to the big city, Omprakash is a eunuch and Ishvar has gotten his legs amputated due to an infection. Around the same time, Maneck gets rejected from continuing on at college, and Dina gets evicted from her house after Beggarmaster is murdered and she is left vulnerable.

About eight years later, Maneck comes back from a job in Dubai to the city where he once went to college. The Prime Minister's Sikh bodyguards have just assassinated her, leading to riots against Sikhs across the country. Maneck learns from an old newspaper article that his old friend Avinash, who disappeared, likely died in police custody. He goes to Nusswan's house to see Dina, who is about to get a visit from Ishvar and Omprakash, but Maneck doesn't stay long enough to meet them.

As Maneck is leaving Dina's, he happens to run into Ishvar and Omprakash. Seeing the two of them as beggars, Maneck feels sad and thinks that they don't recognize him. Later that day, Maneck commits suicide by jumping in front of a moving express train.

As it turns out, Ishvar and Omprakash *did* recognize Maneck but just thought he was ignoring them. They arrive at Dina's and have a meal with her. She has been feeding them in secret for a long time. When the meal is over, Dina sends them off, and Ishvar and Omprakash laugh with each other until it's time to hit the streets and act like beggars again. Dina washes the dishes so that Nusswan and his wife can use them later.



CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

Ishvar – Ishvar is Dukhi and Roopa's son, Narayan's older brother, and Omprakash's uncle. He is a Chamaar who has a mark on his left cheek. Ishvar spends most of his time with Omprakash after Thakur Dharamsi kills the rest of their family because Narayan complained about rigged voting in an election. Although Ishvar spends much of the novel in a precarious living situation, sometimes homeless, he holds onto his faith that things will work out in the end. This leads him to

be deferential toward authority figures like his employer Dina (for whom he and Omprakash work as tailors), whereas Omprakash is more rebellious. Still, Ishvar's faith in traditional authority faces challenges over the course of the novel as he continues to see how figures like Thakur Dharamsi, Sergeant Kesar, and even the Prime Minister take advantage of their power to oppress others. Eventually, Ishvar is subjected to forced sterilization and has his legs amputated due to an infection, and he ends the novel as a beggar. But he still has companionship with Dina and Omprakash and can even still laugh with his nephew, showing his resilience in the face of difficulties.

Omprakash – Omprakash is Ishvar's nephew and Narayan's son. He is a Chamaar who is unusually skinny, due to a parasitic worm that he doesn't learn about until near the end of the novel. Although Omprakash loves and respects Ishvar, he is often more impulsive and rebellious than his uncle. Whereas Ishvar puts his faith in their employer, Dina, to help them out of poverty, Omprakash schemes of ways to go behind Dina's back and try to work independently as tailors. Although many of Omprakash experiences his skepticism toward authority he also learns how to trust people like Dina and find a sense of community. Ishvar's dream of helping Omprakash start a family is crushed near the end of the novel when Thakur Dharamsi forcibly castrates Omprakash. But Omprakash sticks with his uncle and holds onto his sense of humor, showing resilience even after so many years of living in poverty.

Maneck – Maneck is Farokh and Aban's son who rents a room from Dina when he's a student in college. Compared to Dina's tailors Ishvar and Omprakash, Maneck is of a higher social class. He often struggles to get along with his peers at college, though, with the exception of a friend named Avinash who disappears shortly after the start of the Emergency. Maneck is caught at a transition period in India's history, with the soda business that made his father rich now crowded out by larger competitors, forcing Maneck to go to college to try to find a new way to make a living. Maneck temporarily finds a makeshift family living at Dina's with Ishvar and Omprakash. But when he takes a job in Dubai, he begins to feel disconnected from both his biological family and his new found family. In the Epilogue, Maneck kills himself by jumping in front of a train. His death represents that idea that the new industrialized era in India can cause people to feel desperately alienated.

Dina – Dina is Dr. Shroff and Mrs. Shroff's daughter and Nusswan's sister. She eventually marries Rustom, only to live as a widow after his death in a bicycle accident. What Dina wants most is independence, but she struggles to get it from her brother Nusswan, who wants to help Dina but has very conservative ideas about women's place in society. In order to afford rent on her own place, Dina hires Ishvar and Omprakash to work for her as tailors and also takes on Maneck as a renter in her home. For a while, this allows Dina to stay independent,

and she even begins to build a kind of family with Ishvar, Omprakash, and Maneck as she gets to know them better. But several factors—in particular, pressure from Dina's landlord—make this blissful time short-lived, and when Dina loses her home, she is forced to move back in with Nusswan. Although the course of Dina's life shows how it was difficult for Indian women—even in the middle class—to achieve independence during this era, Dina manages to reconnect with Omprakash and Ishvar after losing her old home. This outcome shows how friendship has the potential to endure extreme challenges and how some friends can become like family.

Nusswan – Nusswan is Dina's brother and Ruby's husband. He disobeys the wishes of his father, Dr. Shroff, and instead of training to become a medical doctor, he gets involved in the import and export business. After the deaths of their parents, Nusswan is often very strict with Dina. Although he softens his approach toward her a little as he ages, he continues to hold very conservative views about a woman's place in society, and he praises the Prime Minister and her handling of the Emergency. Nusswan represents a rising middle class in India who have been able to prosper during the tumultuous period of the Emergency by focusing on "traditional" Indian values, even when that sometimes means turning a blind eye to oppression.

Prime Minister – The Prime Minister of India is never referred to by name in the novel, but she is strongly implied to be a lightly fictionalized version of Indira Gandhi, who held office during the same time period the novel takes place in and also oversaw a real period in Indian history known as the Emergency. Prime Minister rose to power during a hopeful period in Indian history, a couple of decades after the country declared independence from Britain. But for many in the novel, particularly lower-class characters, Prime Minister's time in power is a time full of corruption and oppression, in which goondas and other criminals hold power and authority figures like the police are corrupt. In the novel, Prime Minister represents the failure of the Indian government during this time period to live up to its promises to most citizens. The decision to end the novel after the assassination of Prime Minister (which, as in real life, led to riots) shows how the early promise of an independent India has turned into something more complicated.

Rajaram – Rajaram is a friend of Ishvar and Omprakash whom they meet in the slum of the unnamed city where much of the novel takes place. He is more accustomed to living in poverty than they are and has found an unusual way of making a living by selling human hair. But as conditions worsen in the city and make life harder, Rajaram changes and eventually murders two other beggars for their hair. After this, Rajaram goes away and then comes back, rebranding himself as the holy man Bal Baba and selling fraudulent hair-growth products. The fact that Rajaram only succeeds after embracing a scam lifestyle reflects the prevalence of corruption during this period of Indian

history.

Beggarmaster – Beggarmaster both protects and extorts money from beggars in the city where most of the novel takes place. He learns that he's the half-brother of Shankar, one of many beggars who, under Beggarmaster's orders, underwent "procedures" at a young age to remove limbs or give them a disease in order to appear more sympathetic while begging. Despite Beggarmaster's cruelty at times, he becomes an important protector of Dina against her landlord. Beggarmaster embodies the moral gray areas of life during the Emergency, showing how corrupt people could rise to power. But his character also shows how, when it made financial sense, these corrupt figures could do more to promote justice than traditional authority figures. Nevertheless, Beggarmaster dies due to a heavy bag of coins in his hand, symbolizing the consequences of greed.

Ibrahim – Ibrahim is the elderly rent collector who works for Dina's landlord and harasses her throughout the beginning of the novel. But while Ibrahim is very devoted to his job at first, seeing goondas intimidate Dina and start to wreck her home is part of what causes him to question the work he does. By the end of the novel, Ibrahim has given up his job and become a beggar, reflecting how many of the characters in the novel face a decision between doing something morally questionable or living in poverty.

Thakur Dharamsi – Thakur Dharamsi is a thakur who oversees voting and later sterilization camps in the village that Ishvar and Narayan are from. He blatantly abuses his power, reflecting how particularly in more rural areas, corruption and violence could be a regular part of life. Thakur Dharamsi's open contempt for lower-caste people like Chamaars shows the extent of discrimination that existed in this society, even after laws supposed banned treating people as "untouchable."

Vasantao Valmik – Vasantao Valmik is a proofreader and lawyer who eventually gets drawn into writing political speeches and slogans. He talks on a train with Maneck, who thinks Mr. Valmik is like a poet, and later volunteers to be Dina's lawyer. While working this political job, he loses his voice and experiences throat problems because he isn't used to shouting. Mr. Valmik represents how during the Emergency, reason, the written word, and poetry became less valuable, with people forced to adapt to the noisy and fast-paced nature of modern life.

Rustom – Rustom is Dina's husband who is killed in a bicycle accident. His death hangs over much of the story, with Dina unable to move beyond the happiness she once had. Rustom's death also reflects the role random chance plays in the characters' lives as well as how the speed of the modern world (embodied by the truck that hit and killed Rustom) led to casualties.

Shankar – Shankar is a beggar with no legs or hands who gets

around on a wheeled platform called a gaadi. He meets Ishvar and Omprakash at an irrigation work camp, and they are surprised by his positive attitude given his physical condition. Although Shankar is at first a symbol of resilience, he dies in a traffic accident with people laughing at him, showing the cruelty of life in the big city. Shankar's death plays a major role in the character development of his half-brother Beggarmaster, who begins to think about things other than money. Ultimately, though, Beggarmaster meets a similar fate to Shankar.

Narayan – Narayan is Dukhi and Roopa's son, Ishvar's brother, and Omprakash's father. Like the rest of his family, he is a Chamaar. With Ishvar, he goes to the town of Ashraf to become a tailor, although he stays more loyal to the village he grew up in than Ishvar, who is eager to see new places. When Narayan attempts to challenge Thakur Dharamsi and cast a real vote, instead of just providing his thumbprint to allow the thakur to fix the votes, Narayan gets killed. Much of his family is killed, too, in order to intimidate others into never questioning corrupt voting practices.

Avinash – Avinash is a friend of Maneck's who teaches him how to play chess. He gets involved in college politics and manages to improve food in the dining hall, but he disappears shortly after the start of the Emergency and eventually turns up dead. He was likely targeted due to his political organizing.

Farokh – Farokh is Maneck's father and Aban's husband. He runs a soda empire, Kohlah's Cola, that used to be dominant but can't compete in modern, industrialized India. He gives conflicting signals to Maneck, praising him for going away to try to get an education while also chastising him for leaving his home behind.

Monkey-man – Monkey-man is a resident of the same slum as Ishvar and Omprakash who has an act that involves two monkeys and a dog. At one point, though, he leaves the dog and monkeys unsupervised for too long, and the dog eats the monkeys. Around the same time, Beggarmaster separates Monkey-man from his niece and nephew. Monkey-man is never the same after this. In his rage over everything that has happened, he kills Beggarmaster, unintentionally getting rid of the only person who was protecting Dina from her landlord.

Sergeant Kesar – Sergeant Kesar is a police sergeant who clears out slums as part of "beautification" but who is deeply corrupt and spares the slums of people who bribe him. As he confesses later to Dina, however, his actions have begun to weigh on him, and he claims to only continue with his immoral work because he has a family that depends on him.

MINOR CHARACTERS

Ashraf – Ashraf is a Muslim tailor who trains Ishvar and Narayan as apprentices. They come to see him as a father figure, and one day they return the favor by protecting him from a mob during a period of violence against Muslims.

Aban – Aban is Maneck's mother and Farokh's wife. Like her husband, she wants Maneck to be able to succeed in modern India, but she regrets how Maneck's work carries him off to college in a big city and later to Dubai.

Zenobia – Zenobia is a friend of Dina's who cuts hair and who helps to bring about the arrangement where Maneck comes to live with her.

Mrs. Gupta – Mrs. Gupta is the wife of a textile magnate who employs Dina to create dresses for her (with the help of Ishvar and Omprakash). Like many wealthy characters in the novel, she is in favor of the current government, praising Prime Minister's handling of the Emergency.

Dukhi – Dukhi, a Chamaar in a small village, is Roopa's husband. He takes the unusual step of rejecting the traditional Chamaar trade of leather-working in order to teach his sons, Ishvar and Narayan, about tailoring. Ultimately, Dukhi and much of his family die at the hand of Thakur Dharamsi.

Nawaz – Nawaz is a friend of Ashraf's who is much less hospitable than him. He does the bare minimum to help Ishvar and Omprakash adjust to life in a new city, reflecting a general attitude of indifference toward poor people in the city.

The Facilitator – The Facilitator is a mysterious figure who sells black market ration cards and who makes money by rounding up unhoused people to work as free labor on government projects. He embodies the indifferent, profit-first attitude that many characters in the novel have.

Ruby – Ruby is Nusswan's wife. Although she enjoys having Dina around the house, Dina often feels out of place in Nusswan's strictly traditional household, which Ruby helps uphold.

Nightwatchman – An unnamed nightwatchman takes a risk to himself by allowing Ishvar and Omprakash to sleep near his post for a small fee. This small kindness provides them with stability, but it ends abruptly when the nightwatchman isn't there one day, showing how volatile life in the city can be.

Foreman – A foreman oversees work at an irrigation work camp. He helps to enforce harsh conditions on the workers, some of whom are paid and some of whom are unpaid laborers from the slums.

Dr. Shroff – Dr. Shroff is Dina and Nusswan's father and Mrs. Shroff's husband. He is selfless, perhaps to the point of recklessness, and dies while traveling for his medical work.

Mrs. Shroff – Mrs. Shroff is Dina and Nusswan's mother and Dr. Shroff's wife. After her husband's death, she seems to become empty and shrink away from society.

Xerxes – Xerxes is Nusswan and Ruby's first son. Rustom is killed in a bicycle accident on his way to get ice cream for Xerxes and his brother Zarir.

Zarir – Zarir is Nusswan and Ruby's second son. Rustom is

killed in a bicycle accident on his way to get ice cream for Zarir and his brother Xerxes.

Roopa – Roopa is Dukhi's wife and Ishvar and Narayan's mother. Like much of her family, she dies in a fire that Thakur Dharamsi starts.

Radha – Radha is Narayan's wife and Omprakash's mother who dies in a fire that Thakur Dharamsi starts.

Shanti – Shanti is a girl whom Omprakash sees getting water. Although he thinks of her often, he does not see her in person again.

Leela – Leela is Omprakash's sister who dies in the fire that Thakur Dharamsi starts.

Rekha – Rekha is Omprakash's sister who dies in the fire that Thakur Dharamsi starts.

Nosey – Nosey is Shankar's mother. She is named Nosey because she doesn't have a nose.

Pandit Lalluram – Pandit Lalluram is a Brahmin who has a reputation as a peacemaker but who annoys Dukhi with his strict belief in the caste system.

Fredoon – Fredoon is a man with whom Dina has a brief relationship after Rustom's death.

TERMS

The Emergency – The Emergency, which took place from 1975–1977, was a period when the prime minister of India declared a state of emergency in the country. During this time, political elections were put on hold and certain rights were stripped from Indian citizens. **Avinash** explains to **Maneck** that although the Emergency is supposedly a way to deal with a moment of crisis in the country, many believe that it is simply a way for the **Prime Minister** to hold onto power and overcome allegations that she cheated in a recent election.

Caste System – The Hindu caste system in India is a hierarchy that ranks people into different social classes. A person's place in the caste system largely determines how others perceive and treat them. Brahmins are at the top of the caste system, while Chamaars are a low caste.

Brahmin – Brahmins are the priest caste at the top of the Hindu caste system. They tend to occupy high positions in society, in contrast to most of the characters in the novel, who tend to come from the lower or middle class.

Chamaar – Chamaars are a low caste in India that were once considered "untouchable." People in this caste traditionally take up the trade of leather-working. The novel explores how characters from this caste, including **Omprakash** and **Ishvar**, face discrimination even after laws supposedly ban treating any group of people as "untouchable."

Sikhism – Sikhism is an Indian religion and philosophy. Sikhs are

a religious minority in India, which is predominantly Hindu.

Goonda – A goonda is a hired criminal, often employed for intimidation by people like landlords. They are one facet of the rampant corruption in the mid-20th-century India of the novel.

Thakur – Thakur is a title in India similar to the title of “lord” in Europe. The novel explores how thakurs, particularly **Thakur Dharamsi**, sometimes abuse the power they have over common people.



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don't have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



RESILIENCE

Although Rohinton Mistry's *A Fine Balance* features many deaths and chronicles the ends of some institutions in India, it is ultimately a novel about resilience and survival in spite of the odds. At the center of the novel are the lower-caste characters Ishvar and Omprakash, who constantly seem to be in a precarious living situation but who nevertheless find ways to not only survive but to enjoy their lives. Through sheer luck and timing, Ishvar and Omprakash are the only members of their family to survive when the cruel Thakur Dharamsi burns the rest of the family alive. Things don't get any easier when the two of them leave their rural home to live in the city, where they never have enough money and where their new home is suddenly torn down one day. By the end of the novel, Ishvar has lost his legs (leaving him unable to do most tailoring work) and Omprakash has been castrated (leaving him unable to start a family). Still, in the last passage of the book, when they eat lunch with Dina, they are still laughing and joking with each other, showing resilience in spite of everything they've suffered.

Not every character survives to the end of the novel, however. Dina's husband Rustom dies in a bicycling accident. Maneck, a one-time college student who goes to work in Dubai for many years, kills himself shortly after returning to India. The novel acknowledges that resilience is not always possible and that sometimes it is random chance rather than strength of will that determines who lives and who dies. Still, this element of randomness also emphasizes how remarkable the resilience of the surviving characters is. Dina, for example, survives not just the death of her husband but also the loss of her house (and most of the independence that came with it). She, Ishvar, and Omprakash all manage to find the titular “balance” in their lives of facing the dark side of life while still finding ways to survive and even be happy. *A Fine Balance* depicts how harsh life could

be in mid-20th-century India for people of many different backgrounds, but it also demonstrates that, in spite of the obstacles, some people still found ways to be resilient and survive.



CORRUPTION

Much of *A Fine Balance* takes place during a period in Indian history sometimes called the Emergency, when Prime Minister Indira Gandhi declared a state of emergency. Despite the Prime Minister's speeches about bringing order to the country, Mistry depicts the opposite, showing how the government and the justice system became corrupted during this time period. One result is that elections became rigged, with people like Thakur Dharamsi controlling the voting process and punishing or even killing anyone who opposed him. During the Emergency, police like Sergeant Kesar are tools of the government who spend much of their time harassing people in slums and who can't do anything if average citizens complain to them. The end result of this oppression is that lower-class people like Omprakash and Ishvar suffer, as they attempt to make a legitimate living but are ultimately forced into begging by government policies (like the clearing of slums) that make it impossible for them to keep a stable job.

Still, while Mistry's portrayal of corruption during the Emergency is largely negative, there are also moral shades of gray among the characters. One of the most complicated figures is Beggarmaster, who sends small children to be mutilated in order to be better beggars and who charges hefty fees from the people who work for him. In spite of his greed and cruelty, however, Beggarmaster also seems to make genuine attempts to help the people under his protection, most notably his half-brother Shankar, but also Dina when protecting her from her landlord. Similarly, characters like the rent collector Ibrahim and even Sergeant Kesar have regrets about how their actions help prop up a corrupt system. *A Fine Balance* portrays the violence and suffering that go along with corruption, leading to widespread societal decay, but it also suggests that even a corrupt system can leave room for moral gray areas and unusual alliances as people struggle to survive.



CLASS AND CASTE

A Fine Balance explores Indian identity and specifically the role of class, often in the form of the hierarchical caste system. Over the course of the novel, it technically becomes illegal to discriminate against lower-caste groups like the Chamaars by treating them as “untouchable.” Nevertheless, discrimination continues to exist in many forms, particularly toward people at the bottom of the social ladder. Even after the new laws and after leaving their village, Ishvar and Omprakash continue to experience discrimination, getting treated as worthless or expendable by

people like Sergeant Kesar and the man known as the Facilitator. Even sympathetic characters like Dina often feel the need to distinguish themselves from lower-class and lower-caste people like her employees. Dina may resent her own employer, the higher-class Mrs. Gupta, but in spite of the fact that Dina herself doesn't have much money, she initially resists breaking the social hierarchy, refusing to let Ishvar or Omprakash eat at the table with her until later in the story—showing how deeply embedded these differences are.

As the novel also shows, however, as much as the upper classes may try to distinguish themselves from the lower classes, the two groups mutually depend on each other. One of the biggest examples is the Prime Minister's rally. Despite the fact that the Prime Minister has a seemingly ironclad grip on the government and on running elections, to maintain peace, she still needs to give at least the appearance of support from the lower classes—like when people from the nearby slums are bused in to one of her speeches, in order to give the appearance that they support her. The power and privilege that the upper class enjoys, then, is only possible due to their ability to control and exploit the lower classes. In *A Fine Balance*, the author depicts people considered lower class or lower caste as sympathetic and dignified in spite of the prejudice they suffer, and in this way, he argues that whether the upper class acknowledges it or not, the lower class plays a foundational role in society.



THE MEANING OF FAMILY

Rohinton Mistry's *A Fine Balance* is all about families, both blood relatives and more unconventional families. The novel begins with

Ishvar and Omprakash, who are related as uncle and nephew but who start to take on a much closer relationship after the deaths of their other family members. Ishvar becomes like a father to Omprakash, reflecting how Ishvar himself had an unconventional father figure in the Muslim tailor Ashraf, in addition to his biological father Dukhi. For a period of time, Ishvar and Omprakash become part of a new unconventional family unit with their employer Dina and her renter, the student Maneck. Despite initially beginning with a business relationship, the four of them eventually start cooking meals together and eating at the same table, helping to compensate for the losses that each has experienced in their lives (Ishvar and Omprakash for the deaths of their family members; Dina for the death of her husband and the inability of her biological brother Nusswan to understand her; and Maneck for his homesickness and the disappearance of his friend Avinash).

But despite the benefits of being part of a family, the government in India during the Emergency often seems intent on breaking families up. The "Family Planning" sterilization camps try to control how people form families, and a forced castration even prevents Omprakash from ever marrying.

Similarly, the government does nothing to stop Beggarmaster from taking Monkey-man's niece and nephew, and Dina's landlord finds an excuse to evict her, breaking up the makeshift family she has formed in her home with Maneck, Omprakash, and Ishvar. Families provide support and comfort in the novel, and so the characters and institutions that break apart families are generally portrayed as corrupt or oppressive. In *A Fine Balance*, the author suggests that the meaning of family is ever-changing, with families forming or being pulled apart by circumstances, but that, at the same time, family provides an irreplaceable bedrock of stability and support in difficult times.



RELIGION AND VIOLENCE

Mistry's *A Fine Balance* explores the deep religious divisions in India, particularly during the Emergency, and how these divisions can lead to violence. A major conflict is that between Hinduism and Islam. During a period of religious tension, Ashraf, the Muslim shop owner, nearly has his shop attacked by Hindus who once would have viewed him as a neighbor. The novel concludes with a similar outbreak of violence in the Epilogue, where riots after the assassination of Prime Minister lead to the deaths of many Sikhs (a religious minority in India) as well as the destruction of their businesses. In both cases, religion, which can be a source of community, instead becomes the opposite, violently tearing apart communities that once lived in relative harmony. The most positive characters in the story are often ones like Ishvar and Omprakash who can see beyond religious differences and help people of other religions, like when, despite being Hindus, they intervene to save the Muslim Ashraf's shop. Particularly through tolerant characters like Ishvar and Omprakash, the author suggests that while religion can harmfully radicalize people, it is just as possible for people to find community and live in harmony beyond religious divisions.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



DINA'S QUILT

Dina sews a quilt from scraps of fabric that she's picked up over the years, and the patchwork of the quilt symbolizes both the patchwork nature of the new family unit she puts together after the death of her husband, Rustom. It also represents how India in general is a patchwork collection of people from different backgrounds with a common nationality. Dina's quilt is made up of different materials that she's collected from various sewing jobs that she, Ishvar, and Omprakash perform. On a basic level, Dina's decision to work with scraps helps to convey the difficult economic conditions in

India during the Emergency and how those conditions encourage people to become thrifty. The quilt is Dina's best attempt to make something beautiful out of the meager materials she's been given. This represents her approach to life in general, as she tries to rebuild her family after Rustom's death by slowly getting to know Ishvar, Omprakash, and Maneck—first merely as her means to make money but eventually as friends. In their own way, Ishvar, Omprakash, and Maneck are each the “scraps” of society who have been left behind in some way, but Dina finds a way to unite them all just as she does with the scraps of her quilt.

Quilts also come up in a speech that Maneck gives. In this speech, he says that God is like a quilt-maker who treated creation like quilt with elaborate patterns but who got confused by the patterns and let creation go on its own. A patchwork quilt, then, becomes a metaphor for the inherent chaos of the world. When Dina makes her quilt, she is, in her own way, trying to make sense of the confusion in India around the time of the Emergency and process difficult events like the death of Rustom or her eviction from her home. Making the quilt, in a sense, represents Dina's search for purpose in life, and the purpose she finds is helping other people. This idea is reflected in what ultimately becomes of the quilt: originally, Dina wants to give the quilt to Omprakash as a wedding present. But after Omprakash is forcibly castrated, Dina instead gives it to Ishvar as a cushion to use on his gaadi (which he needs to move around after his legs are amputated). Ultimately, then, Dina's patchwork quilt represents how things or people that seem like forgotten, isolated “scraps” can unite to form something beautiful, putting aside differences to create unity from chaos and make a larger whole.

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 3

Explanation and Analysis

This quote is the beginning of the novel and establishes the initial setting as a fast-moving train that starts and stops. It also introduces the main characters of Maneck, Omprakash, and Ishvar, as the jerkiness of the train literally causes Omprakash to bump into Maneck. And so, the novel begins by demonstrating how urban life can bring together people of different backgrounds in unexpected ways.

This introduction also helps establish the status of the various characters in the novel. Maneck is standing “propped up securely” holding books in his hand, signifying his comparatively comfortable middle-class standing in life. Meanwhile, the thin Omprakash is “catapulted” around by the velocity of the train, signifying how because of his poorer status, he is more at the mercy of forces around him. The train, a symbol of the new industrialized India, is more powerful than any of the passengers, tossing them around at its mercy, which represents how industrialization has changed life for many Indians whether they like it or not.

Chapter 1 Quotes

☞ “I don't want to be a doctor,” Nusswan answered. “I'll be going into business—import and export.”

Some of the uncles and aunts nodded approvingly. Others recoiled in mock horror, turning to Dr. Shroff. “Is this true? No father-son partnership?”

“Of course it's true,” he said. “My children are free to do whatever they please.”

Related Characters: Nusswan, Dr. Shroff (speaker), Dina

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 16

Explanation and Analysis

In this quote, which takes place several years before the Prologue, Nusswan makes the fateful choice to go into business instead of following his father, Dr. Shroff, into the medical profession. The fact that Nusswan specifically wants to get into the import and export business shows how he is interested in international trade, reflecting a modern and more global India. The divide between father and son also reflects a divide between selflessness and selfishness,



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Vintage edition of *A Fine Balance* published in 1997.

Prologue Quotes

☞ The morning express bloated with passengers slowed to a crawl, then lurched forward suddenly, as though to resume full speed. The train's brief deception jolted its riders. The bulge of humans hanging out of the doorway distended perilously, like a soap bubble at its limit.

Inside the compartment, Maneck Kohlah held on to the overhead railing, propped up securely within the crush. He felt someone's elbow knock his textbooks from his hand. In the seats nearby, a thin young fellow was catapulted into the arms of the man opposite him. Maneck's textbooks fell upon them.

Related Characters: Ishvar , Omprakash , Maneck

with Dr. Shroff dedicated to helping even people who can't afford his services while Nusswan seeks to enter an industry that is almost entirely about making a profit.

Dr. Shroff accepts Nusswan's decision, giving Nusswan a level of freedom that few parents in the story offer to their children. Ironically, in spite of his own freedom during childhood to become whatever he wanted, Nusswan himself becomes obsessed with traditional values in his own family, even though he rejected the opportunity to continue in the same trade as his father. In the novel, the replacement of selfless men like Dr. Shroff with more self-interested men like Nusswan becomes a dark omen for the future of India.

☛ A stray dog lapped at the thick pink puddle near the bicycle. Strawberry ice cream was in stock, thought Dina numbly. A policeman kicked the sand-coloured mongrel. It yelped and retreated, then returned for more. When he kicked it again, she screamed.

"Stop that! What harm is it doing to you? Let it eat!"

Startled, the policeman said "Yes madam" and stepped back. The dog slurped hungrily, whimpering with pleasure while keeping a wary eye on the man's foot.

Related Characters: Dina (speaker), Rustom

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 45

Explanation and Analysis

This quote describes Dina's reaction in the moments after learning that Rustom has most likely died in a bicycle accident. The strawberry ice cream, which Rustom died trying to get, represents his blood with its red color. The policeman kicks the dog, perhaps feeling that the dog is trying to take advantage of Rustom's death and the ice cream he dropped or perhaps just feeling cruel. But Dina scolds the police officer, revealing that even in her moment of grief, she knows that the dog has nothing to do with Rustom's death, so there's no need to make it suffer.

Hungry dogs become a running theme in the novel, representing how hunger can make creatures wild and make humans more like creatures. The dog, which keeps a "wary eye" on the policeman's foot, represents how, in general, surviving on the streets of the city involves looking out for opportunities for food and also watching out for potential violence, even from institutions like the police that are supposed to offer protection.

Chapter 2 Quotes

☛ Ibrahim was an elderly man but looked old beyond his years. In his left hand, still sore from pounding the door yesterday, he carried a plastic folder secured by two large rubber bands. It contained rent receipts, bills, orders for repairs, records of disputes and court cases pertaining to the six buildings he looked after. Some of those disputes dated back to when he was a young man of nineteen, just starting in service with the father of the present landlord. Other cases were more ancient, inherited from Ibrahim's predecessor.

Related Characters: Dina, Ibrahim

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 85

Explanation and Analysis

This quote introduces Ibrahim, the rent collector who harasses Dina on behalf of her landlord. Although he seems at first to be an evil character, based on how he goes out of his way to try to get Dina evicted, this initial description portrays him with hints of sympathy. He looks "old beyond his years" and has to deal with mountains of old documents full of relevant information about the landlord's houses that date back to when he "was a young man of nineteen." Furthermore, in spite of Ibrahim's antagonism toward Dina, he shows that at least he can be loyal toward the landlord and his family.

Ultimately, Ibrahim shows how potentially good people can become corrupted by the environment around them. Ibrahim is someone who cares about doing his job well, and in the city where he lives, doing a job well often means supporting powerful people like landlords and oppressing more vulnerable people like Dina.

Chapter 3 Quotes

☞ Two years after Ishvar was born, Roopa and Dukhi had another son. This one was named Narayan. There was a dark-red mark on his chest, and an elderly neighbour who assisted Roopa during the birth said she had seen such a mark before. “It means he has a brave and generous heart. This child will make you very proud.”

The news of a second son created envy in upper-caste homes where marriages had also taken place around the time Dukhi and Roopa were wed, but where the women were still childless or awaiting a male issue. It was hard for them not to be resentful—the birth of daughters often brought them beatings from their husbands and their husbands’ families. Sometimes they were ordered to discreetly get rid of the newborn. Then they had no choice but to strangle the infant with her swaddling clothes, poison her, or let her starve to death.

Related Characters: Ishvar , Narayan, Dukhi, Roopa

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 99

Explanation and Analysis

This quote takes place in an extended flashback that explores the lives of Narayan and especially Ishvar, who goes on to become one of the main characters in the story. As this passage alludes to, the Chamaar people of this small village have a low social status, but they find support in both their families and their community. Although upper-caste people generally try to avoid mixing with the Chamaars (who were at one point considered “untouchable”), they can’t help looking enviously at Roopa’s two sons. In spite of having a higher social status, these people still experience jealousy over what they don’t have.

This passage also casually references the infanticide of female babies, hinting at how women in this society face the possibility of violence starting at the moment of birth. When the narration states that families “had no choice but to strangle the infant with her swaddling clothes,” it reflects the gender biases of these upper-caste families, not the views of the author himself. The families believe they have “no choice” but to kill females because they are unable to see options beyond their own prejudices.

☞ “The Muslims have behaved more like our brothers than the bastard Brahmins and Thakurs.”

Related Characters: Ishvar , Narayan, Ashraf, Dukhi

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 123

Explanation and Analysis

This quote, from an anonymous friend of Dukhi’s, sums up the absurdity of the riots against Muslims that occurred in the years after Indian independence. Although many Hindus see Muslims as enemies, based on their different religious beliefs, Dukhi and his friends feel like they have more in common with Muslims, perhaps in part because of Dukhi’s personal friendship with Ashraf.

As this quote notes, the divisions in Indian society are about more than just Hinduism versus Islam. Brahmins and Thakurs are both members of society’s upper class, at the total opposite end of the spectrum from the Chamaars like Dukhi, who are on the lowest level of society. Dukhi and his friends realize that, while some people may side against Muslims due to a belief in Hinduism, the Chamaars might actually have more in common with Muslims, who are also outcasts from mainstream society. This passage explores how there are multiple types of identity, with religion, wealth, and social status all playing a role in how people come together or become enemies.

☞ “We’ll go as soon as we mark our ballots,” said Narayan. “It is our right.”

Related Characters: Narayan (speaker), Ishvar , Prime Minister, Thakur Dharamsi

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 145

Explanation and Analysis

With this quote, Narayan seals his fate, unknowingly condemning himself to death by challenging the authority of Thakur Dharamsi to count the votes. Although Thakur Dharamsi is not such a powerful man in the grand scheme of things, within the small village where he lives, he is a tyrant who can do what he wants—even kill people—without fear of repercussions for his actions. The corruption of Thakur Dharamsi, who makes little effort to hide the fact that he is rigging the votes, stands in for the corruption of the Indian government as a whole, foreshadowing the concerns about fair elections that will lead Prime Minister to declare the Emergency and suspend several civil liberties.

Up until this point in the story, Narayan has typically been more cautious and conservative than his brother Ishvar. But it's this very faith in authority—this idea that it's "our right" to cast a fair vote—which leads him to challenge Thakur Dharamsi, underestimating how far the cruel Thakur will go to teach his opponents a lesson.

Chapter 4 Quotes

☞☞ "And how do you collect the hair?" asked Om. "Steal it from people's heads?" There was a sneer in his voice.

Rajaram laughed good-naturedly. "I go to pavement barbers. They let me take it in exchange for a packet of blades, or soap, or a comb. In haircutting saloons they give it free if I sweep the floor myself. Come—come inside my house, I'll show you my stock."

Related Characters: Omprakash, Rajaram (speaker), Ishvar, Nusswan, Dr. Shroff

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 172

Explanation and Analysis

In this quote, Rajaram describes his unusual method of earning a living by selling unwanted hair abroad in order to make a profit. At first, Rajaram sounds like he might be delusional, but as he talks more, he begins to describe his collection in a way that sounds rational. Rajaram's methods of getting hair reveal that in the slums where money is scarce, barter and other reciprocal transactions take on a more prominent role.

The fact that Rajaram had to switch from being a barber to selling hair abroad is a humorous commentary on how India has changed during his lifetime. In many ways, Rajaram's new career resembles the generational change between Dr. Shroff and Nusswan, going from a locally focused, service-based job to one more focused on international markets. The language that Rajaram uses, like "stock," reinforces that he treats his strange venture like a real business. Ultimately, Rajaram's hair-selling practice draws attention to how people in the slums are both disposable and highly valuable to the upper classes—while no one wants to provide food or housing to slum residents, foreign buyers will pay a premium for their hair.

Chapter 5 Quotes

☞☞ "Don't worry," said his mother. "Everything will be all right when you come back after a year. Daddy is just concerned about your future. All these changes—they have happened too fast for him. He should be calmer in a year's time."

Related Characters: Aban (speaker), Maneck, Farokh

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 220

Explanation and Analysis

In this quote, Aban tries to smooth over the growing generational divide between her husband, Farokh, and their son, Maneck. As Maneck gets older, he starts to develop his own ideas about how the world works, and one of the first things he wants to do is change Farokh's old-fashioned soda-selling store. This angers Farokh, who likes things to remain the same, and it causes a rift within the family that never fully goes away.

The conflict between Farokh and Maneck is interesting because each side makes valuable points. Maneck is correct to want to modernize the soda store, which seems primed to fall to the bigger corporations selling mass-produced products. At the same time, however, Farokh is correct that the modern world has brought negative changes to the mountains where he lives (including pollution) and that perhaps Maneck would be better off trying to learn a different trade altogether. Aban's own calm tone offers the promise that perhaps Farokh and Maneck will one day see eye-to-eye, but ultimately, Maneck's departure from the home only leads him to grow further and further apart from his family.

☞☞ "Hang on for a minute. What's the point of thrashing these guys? The crooked caterer is the one to blame."

Related Characters: Avinash (speaker), Maneck

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 240

Explanation and Analysis

This quote is one of the defining character moments for Avinash, Maneck's friend who helps him adjust to the often-difficult life in the student hostel where he moves after leaving his family. The "guys" that Avinash refers to are kitchen workers who served non-vegetarian food to

vegetarian eaters, possibly without realizing what they were doing. Although many in the college (where violent initiation rituals called “ragging” thrive) want to beat up the kitchen workers, Avinash urges moderation and protest instead of violence.

This passage portrays Avinash as part of a long tradition of nonviolent protest in India, in which Mahatma Gandhi is perhaps the most famous figure. Like Gandhi, Avinash achieves change, but also like Gandhi, Avinash suffers a violent death that contrasts with how he lived in life. Avinash’s short life shows the benefits of going against mob rule and advocating for a more peaceful world, but it also shows the dangers and sacrifices that can happen as a result.

Chapter 6 Quotes

☞ “He played with them like brother and sister,” he wept. “All three were like my children. And now this. I’ll kill him.”

Related Characters: Monkey-man (speaker), Prime Minister, Rustom

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 267

Explanation and Analysis

In this quote, Monkey-man laments that his dog, Tikka, has just killed the two monkeys that were part of his act, all while Monkey-man was being forced to attend a speech by Prime Minister. Monkey-man notes that, although in normal conditions, the dog and the monkey got along “like brother and sister,” the dog’s long period of hunger caused it to turn violent against its former playmates.

The dog’s desperate behavior, which in some ways recalls the hungry dog eating strawberry ice cream after Rustom’s death, shows how hunger and desperation can bring out the dark side of an animal (or person). In turn, the dog’s killing of the monkeys makes Monkey-man want to kill the dog, highlighting how cycles of violence can continue, all spurred by one desperate act. The sad story of Monkey-man and his dog is a microcosm of the story of how poverty can turn allies against each other, hinting at some of the reasons for the violence that runs throughout the novel.

Chapter 7 Quotes

☞ The bulldozers finished flattening the rows of flimsy shacks and tackled the high-rental ones, reversing and crunching into the brick walls. Om felt nothing—the shack had meant nothing to him, he decided. Maybe now his uncle would agree to go back to Ashraf Chacha. He remembered Maneck, coming to visit tomorrow. He laughed mirthlessly about telling him the dinner was off—cancelled due to the unexpected disappearance of their house.

Sergeant Kesar’s megaphone blared in the dusk: “Work will be stopping for thirty minutes. Actually speaking, this is simply to give you a chance to collect your personal belongings. Then the machines will start again.”

Related Characters: Sergeant Kesar (speaker), Ishvar, Omprakash, Ashraf

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 292

Explanation and Analysis

In this quote, Omprakash and Ishvar come home to their hut in the slum just in time to see makeshift bulldozers tearing apart the whole encampment. The bulldozers literally return everyone to the same level, demolishing the flimsiest dwellings and the more stable ones with equal ease. Omprakash’s numbness to watching his home get destroyed reveals how his lifestyle in poverty doesn’t allow him to get too attached to things or places. He even manages to laugh a little, albeit “mirthlessly,” over the idea that he and Ishvar can’t invite Maneck to dinner because they don’t have a house anymore.

This passage also highlights how figures like Sergeant Kesar, who as a police sergeant should stand for justice, instead become tools for spreading corruption. As the novel later reveals, some slumlords were able to avoid having their sections cleared due to connections or bribes. Although Sergeant Kesar presents his thirty-minute break in bulldozing as a kind gesture to help the slum residents collect their things, ultimately, he represents how in a corrupt society, even the justice system can become a tool for oppression.

Chapter 8 Quotes

☞ “Now I prefer to think that God is a giant quiltmaker. With an infinite variety of designs. And the quilt is grown so big and confusing, the pattern is impossible to see, the squares and diamonds and triangles don’t fit well together anymore, it’s all become meaningless. So He has abandoned it.”

Related Characters: Maneck (speaker), Dina

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 334

Explanation and Analysis

In this quote, Maneck outlines his theory that God is like a giant quiltmaker. “God” is already a complicated concept, meaning something different to a Hindu or a Muslim, and Maneck describes a situation even more confusing, with God as a creator figure who has lost track of what he created, symbolized by his wildly patterned quilt. The complicated “squares and diamonds and triangles” on the quilt that God makes represent the complexity of creation, but for Maneck, the most important part of this theory is that God has abandoned his creation, leaving everything to humans to work out on their own.

Maneck’s theory is more of a metaphor and not necessarily his sincere religious belief, although he does seem to genuinely believe in a world without an active God in it. Maneck’s theory no doubt takes inspiration from the quilt that Dina constantly works on, which is its own act of creation. But while Dina remains optimistic that she can unite various scraps into one united quilt, Maneck believes this job is too much for his God, reflecting his own more pessimistic worldview.

☞ The beggar was having none of that, and soon returned with a full mug. He inquired if they wanted extra chapatis. “I made friends with someone in the kitchen, I can get as many as I like.”

Related Characters: Shankar (speaker), Ishvar , Omprakash , Foreman

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 342

Explanation and Analysis

This quote comes from the introduction of Shankar, a legless beggar with no hands who gets to know Ishvar and Omprakash at a camp where they perform forced, unpaid work on an irrigation canal. Unlike the foreman of the camp, who has a higher status but who offers Ishvar and Omprakash the bare minimum to survive, Shankar has almost nothing in life, but he still offers what little he has to Ishvar and Omprakash, who are near-strangers to him at this point.

The generosity of Shankar, who struggles even with basic movement because of his physical condition, is yet another example in the story of how sometimes the most generous people are the ones with the least to give, while the greediest people are the ones who already have wealth. Shankar’s lack of legs highlights his lack of mobility in life—physically and economically—but his friendly attitude shows how resilience is possible even in the most unfortunate people.

Chapter 9 Quotes

☞ The children were lifted high above the ground. Their faces disappeared into the night, beyond the reach of the kitchen lights. The audience gasped. He raised the pole higher, gave it a little toss, and caught the end upon his palm. His stringy arm muscles quivered. He moved the pole to and fro, making the top end sway like a treetop in a breeze. Then another little toss, and the pole was balanced on his thumb.

A cascade of protest spilled from the spectators. Doubt and reproach swirled in the area of darkness around Monkey-man. In the deafness of his concentration he heard nothing. He started walking back and forth within the circle of light, then running, tossing the pole from thumb to thumb.

Related Characters: Monkey-man

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 356

Explanation and Analysis

This quote describes the new act that Monkey-man comes up with after the deaths of his monkeys, when he gets taken to the irrigation work camp and has to perform to entertain the other camp residents. Without any animals to work with, Monkey-man instead develops an act that involves hoisting his niece and nephew up high on a pole, balancing the whole thing on his thumb. This spectacular feat seems to be part of the reasoning behind the novel’s title, *A Fine Balance*.

In fact, however, while Monkey-man's act is physically impressive, he does not find the right "balance" of thrills to entertain his audience. In his obsession, Monkey-man thinks that the more difficult or dangerous an act is, the more entertaining it must be, not realizing that the audience is too worried for the safety of the children to enjoy Monkey-man's feats. The loss of his animals has made Monkey-man desperate, and people dislike having to witness it. In many ways, Monkey-man's performance embodies the same balancing challenge that author Rohinton Mistry faces with the novel, as he portrays the sometimes dark and tragic elements of life in India in a way that attempts to keep audiences invested in the story rather than going too far and provoking a negative reaction.

Chapter 10 Quotes

☝☝ "Let's have masala wada today," proposed Ishvar. "Rajaram's recipe."

"I don't know how to make that."

"That's okay, I can do it, Dinabai, you relax today." He took charge, sending Om and Maneck to buy a fresh half-coconut, green chillies, mint leaves, and a small bunch of coriander. The remaining ingredients: dry red chillies, cumin seed, and tamarind were in the spice cabinet."

Related Characters: Ishvar, Dina (speaker), Omprakash, Maneck, Rajaram

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 393

Explanation and Analysis

This quote marks a major turning point in the relationship between Dina and her houseguests—Maneck, Ishvar, and Omprakash—as they make the decision to start cooking meals together, with each member of the household taking on a specific role. The end result is something that even Dina admits is better than her solo cooking, revealing how teamwork can result in something greater than the efforts of any one individual.

Cooking is also a common family activity. While Dina initially establishes herself as a mother figure in the family by offering to cook for everyone, Ishvar proposes a more equal arrangement where everyone cooks together. The meal even incorporates people from outside of their house, building off of a recipe that came from Rajaram. The way

that Dina and her guests come together to make a meal resembles how the scraps on her quilt come together to make a unified object, showing how people from different backgrounds can come together to build something greater than themselves.

Chapter 11 Quotes

☝☝ "These Emergency times are terrible, sister. Money can buy the necessary police order. Justice is sold to the highest bidder."

"But what is it to the landlord if my tailors and I sew here?" Her voice rose uncontrollably. "Who am I harming with my work?"

"The landlord needs an excuse, sister. These flats are worth a fortune, the Rent Act lets him charge only the old worthless rent, so he—"

Ibrahim broke off and wiped his eyes. "But you know all that, sister."

Related Characters: Dina, Ibrahim (speaker), Sergeant Kesar

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 424

Explanation and Analysis

Shortly before this quote, Ibrahim breaks down in tears in front of Dina, making a surprising reversal from the strict man that he seemed to be earlier. He admits to her that he realizes the injustice of what he does for the landlord, and he tries to make it up to her by advising her about how to keep her home. Unfortunately, there's not much Ibrahim can tell her that she doesn't already know.

Ibrahim's quote lays bare just how prevalent corruption has become during the Emergency. His claim that "Justice is sold to the highest bidder" reflects how traditional figures of justice like Sergeant Kesar have ended up working for bribes rather than for the common good. Ibrahim also underscores the precariousness of the housing situation in the city, showing how landlords have a profit motivation to kick out old tenants, constructing more expensive buildings and widening the gap between the city's richest and poorest residents.

Chapter 12 Quotes

☛ In the corner, in the hollow where coal fires used to burn for cooking in the old days, lay three brown and white kittens. A chorus of tiny miaows greeted Dina and Maneck as they bent over to look.

Related Characters: Ishvar , Omprakash , Maneck, Dina, Prime Minister

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 442

Explanation and Analysis

In this quote, the cats that sometimes visit Dina's house leave behind three kittens. The three stray kittens that show up in Dina's home seem to be connected to her three new guests—Maneck, Ishvar, and Omprakash—that she keeps in her house. Just as she was with her new guests, Dina is reluctant about keeping the kittens, but this resistance soon goes away as she embraces the unexpected change in her life.

Both the cats and the kittens in Dina's home come and go, sometimes unexpectedly. This mirrors Dina's constant state of uncertainty around her guests, since Ishvar and Omprakash have already disappeared on her twice (once to Prime Minister's speech, once to the irrigation work camp), and there's no guarantee that Maneck will stay after his year of college ends. Still, Ishvar sees the kittens as a good omen, and the new life that they represent seems to suggest possibilities for the future for Dina—even if these possibilities remain precarious and uncertain, like the fate of the kittens.

Chapter 13 Quotes

☛ At some point, Rajaram's fanciful notions took on a serious aspect. Now he began to believe there was no ethical connection between picking pockets and administering unwelcome haircuts. One was a crime, which deprived the victims of their money. The other was a good deed, the alleviation of an encumbrance, the eradication of a lice-breeding pasture, which would save the victims time and effort and itchy scalps, not to mention the frivolous expenses of shampoo and hair lotions. And "victim" was hardly the correct word in this case, he felt. Surely "beneficiary" would be more accurate. Surely it was vanity that kept people from realizing their own good, and a helping hand was necessary. In any case, the loss would be temporary, the hair would grow back.

Related Characters: Ishvar , Omprakash , Rajaram

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 470

Explanation and Analysis

This quote explores Rajaram's struggles to find a new source of income after he loses his government job as a "Motivator" promoting family planning. Whereas before, Rajaram was an eccentric character who remained in some ways a savvy businessman, he is now the likely culprit of a double-murder, and his behavior has become unhinged.

The difference between Rajaram's current description of the hair collecting business and his past work is that he has become more selfish and self-righteous. Previously, he used to barter to get hair, making arrangements with local barbers that were mutually beneficial. Now, Rajaram resorts to taking hair right off people's heads, trying to justify the practice to himself with the idea that people are better off without too much hair after all. Rajaram is not quite greedy—he is poor and needs to make money to survive—but his desperation to survive turns into a mania, ultimately culminating in him killing two fellow beggars in order to avoid getting caught by the police himself. Rajaram's descent into "fanciful notions" highlights the toll that living in poverty can take on people over time, with Rajaram's hunger and need for shelter making him oblivious to the suffering of others.

Chapter 14 Quotes

☛ "Terrible accident. He lost control of his gaadi. Flew off the pavement ... straight into a double-decker bus." He swallowed and said he hadn't witnessed it himself but had identified the remains. "With all my years in this profession, my eyes have seen much that is gruesome. But never anything this horrible. Both Shankar and the gaadi were crushed completely—not possible to separate the two. Removing the wood and castors embedded in his flesh would have meant mutilating his poor body still more. It will have to be cremated with him."

Related Characters: Beggarmaster (speaker), Dina, Shankar, Nosey

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 491

Explanation and Analysis

In this quote, Beggarmaster reflects regretfully on how

Shankar died in a traffic accident. While many people at the scene of Shankar's death were laughing at him right up until the end, Beggarmaster tells the events more somberly in a way that emphasizes the horror of the scene. In the end, Shankar's body can't be separated from his gaadi (the device he used to move). Although he doesn't express it directly, this detail seems to weigh particularly on Beggarmaster's conscience—he is the reason that Shankar needed a gaadi in the first place (because he sent Shankar to have his legs and hands removed by a doctor in a "procedure" to make him a better beggar).

When Beggarmaster sent Shankar for his "procedure," he didn't realize that the two of them were half-brothers (which he only learned recently from Nosey). Now, because of Shankar's death, Beggarmaster will never have a chance to share this knowledge with Shankar. Despite the evil things he's done in the past, Beggarmaster becomes a tragic figure, unintentionally helping to bring about the death of his own half-brother. Beggarmaster's story shows one of the consequences of cruelty—you never know who the stranger you're hurting might really be.

Chapter 15 Quotes

☞☞ "Testicular tumour," he felt obliged to explain to them. "Thakurji has authorized removal, as a special favour to the boy." The quaver in his voice betrayed the lie.

Related Characters: Ishvar, Omprakash, Thakur Dharamsi

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 526

Explanation and Analysis

In this quote, a doctor sent by Thakur Dharamsi lies to Omprakash by telling him that he has a tumor on his testicle. This is all just a ploy by the Thakur to justify castrating Omprakash, in order to make sure that his family line finally ends for good. Thakur Dharamsi's actions are particularly cruel because Omprakash was already infertile due to a vasectomy, which would have been nearly impossible to reverse for someone in Omprakash's financial situation.

This passage is one of the bleakest ones in the novel because it shows both how tyrants like Thakur Dharamsi can go for years without facing any consequences for their actions. It's also dark because it is yet another example of how regular people, like the doctors at the sterilization camp, can recognize that what they're doing is wrong (as shown by the "quaver" in the one doctor's voice) but

nevertheless become a part of the corruption around them. Still, this chapter is not the end of the novel, and while Ishvar's dream of a traditional family for Omprakash seems to be forever ruined, Ishvar and Omprakash are still alive and have found ways to be resilient in the aftermath of all their previous difficulties.

Chapter 16 Quotes

☞☞ What was with him, explained Ibrahim, was the large bag full of coins, chained to his wrist, which he had been out gathering from his beggars. Anchored to the ground by this deadweight, one hand immobilized, he was trapped. He thrashed and flailed with the free arm, kicking his legs about, while the frail murderer laboured on, sitting astride his victim's back, trying to make the blade pass through the clothes, break the skin, enter the flesh and pierce the heart.

Related Characters: Dina, Beggarmaster, Ibrahim, Shankar, Monkey-man

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 454

Explanation and Analysis

This quote, which paraphrases a conversation Ibrahim has with Dina, describes the shocking death of Beggarmaster at the hands of Monkey-man. Beggarmaster took Monkey-man's niece and nephew away from him, seemingly without even a second thought about it. Although Beggarmaster showed signs of reforming himself, being lenient with the money Dina owes him and showing regret for his treatment of Shankar, ultimately, his death shows how he couldn't escape his old ways. Beggarmaster's undoing was the big bag of coins he held, which both metaphorically and literally held him down.

Although Beggarmaster was in many ways not a good person, his death also causes problems for Dina, who relied on his protection in order to keep the goondas away from her home. Beggarmaster seemed like a powerful figure, but his death, which occurs at the hands of a "frail murderer" who takes his time, lays bare how quickly all his influence could go away and how unstable life in the city is in general.

Epilogue Quotes

☞☞ "You haven't guessed? I am a Sikh—I shaved off my beard and cut my hair two days ago. But I'm still wearing my kara." He held up his hand, displaying the iron bangle round his wrist.

Related Characters: Ishvar , Maneck, Prime Minister, Narayan, Ashraf, Farokh

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 573

Explanation and Analysis

This quote comes from near the beginning of the Epilogue, which jumps ahead eight years from where the previous chapter left off. Maneck comes home from Dubai to find Prime Minister assassinated and riots breaking out against Sikh people across the country (because Prime Minister's assassins were her Sikh bodyguards). The death of the Prime Minister comes right around the same time as the death of Maneck's father, marking a clear break for him between a past that will never come back and the present.

But while Maneck learns about the violence and unrest, which resemble the violence against Muslims earlier in the novel, he also learns about how people can still make connections across religious divides. Maneck's Sikh taxi driver puts his own life at risk, taking Maneck to his father's funeral during the riots and revealing his true identity to Maneck. The Sikh driver seems to offer solidarity to Maneck across religious lines, just like Ishvar and Narayan found with Ashraf, but Maneck resists him, trying to get the driver to take off his kara (iron wrist bangle with religious significance) for his own safety. The distance that Maneck keeps from the Sikh driver shows how he has become disconnected from his old home of India.

☞ Now the express could be seen in the distance, having cleared the bend in the tracks. The rumble was louder, growing to a roar as it approached. When the first compartment had entered the station, he stepped off the platform and onto the gleaming silver tracks.

The elderly woman in dark glasses was the first to scream. Then the shriek of the pneumatic brakes drowned all other sounds. The fast train took several hundred yards to stop.

Maneck's last thought was that he still had Avinash's chessmen.

Related Characters: Ishvar , Omprakash , Maneck, Dina, Avinash

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 601

Explanation and Analysis

This quote details the moments right before Maneck's suicide. While Maneck's motivations remain partly mysterious, part of the issue seems to be his increasing feelings of alienation from his old home, including his inability to relate to Dina, Omprakash, and Ishvar as he once did. The fact that Maneck dies in front of an express train brings the novel full circle—everything began with a chance meeting of Maneck, Omprakash, and Ishvar on an express train (which was delayed at one point due to a dead body on the track). The fact that the train takes “several hundred yards to stop” shows how insignificant Maneck is in the face of the industrial power that the train represents.

Maneck's thoughts of Avinash's chessmen could mean several things. He may be thinking of how Avinash himself ended up dead on the train tracks. As Omprakash once complained, chess is a game that doesn't always have a winner, and Maneck's suicide seems to be his answer to a situation that he feels is unwinnable.

☞ “Come on, my faithful,” said Ishvar. “Lift your hoofs or I'll feed you a dose of opium.” Chuckling, Om trotted away plumply. They quit clowning when they emerged into the street.

Dina shut the door, shaking her head. Those two made her laugh every day. Like Maneck used to, once. She washed the two plates, returning them to the sideboard for Nusswan and Ruby to dine off at night. Then she dried her hands and decided to take a nap before starting the evening meal.

Related Characters: Ishvar (speaker), Omprakash , Dina, Nusswan, Ruby

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 603

Explanation and Analysis

This quote is the ending of the novel. Despite the many tragedies that Ishvar and Omprakash have witnessed or endured over the course of the story, Ishvar retains a sense of humor as he and Omprakash leave Dina. This part of their lives has stayed the same, even as other elements have changed drastically, with Omprakash going from extremely thin to “plump.” Although the uncle and nephew still find ways to laugh, they stop “clowning” when they're back on the street as beggars, suggesting that in spite of their humor, they still understand the harsh reality they live in.

Although Maneck saw only a shell of the old Dina when he came back, his perception was skewed. In fact, Omprakash and Ishvar still make Dina laugh every day, suggesting that

even though her dream of living together with them as a family in her own home never came true, she still has been able to find companionship with them and a sense of purpose. The final images of Dina washing plates to prevent Nusswan and Ruby from noticing them, then napping to prepare to make dinner, illustrates the challenges she still

faces. In spite of the joy she gets from Ishvar and Omprakash, she still must perform household duties like cooking, and she must keep her relationship with Ishvar and Omprakash secret from her brother and sister-in-law, who wouldn't understand.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

PROLOGUE

Ishvar Darji and his nephew Omprakash Darji (whom Ishvar calls “Om”) are riding a morning train to a city somewhere in India when a sudden jolt from the train causes them to run into the student Maneck Kohlah, who drops his textbooks. Ishvar has a disfigured left cheek and is not heavy, but he looks big compared to the very skinny Omprakash. Maneck tries to laugh off them hitting him, and they all make small talk, discovering that they’re headed to the same station.

Ishvar, Omprakash, and Maneck hear that the train has stopped because a body was found near the tracks. Someone wonders whether it has anything to do with the Emergency that Prime Minister mentioned in a recent speech on the radio. Ishvar, Omprakash, and Maneck learn that they’re all going to visit the same person: Dina Dalai. Ishvar and Omprakash have come a long way from their village to seek work as tailors, while Maneck’s mother is a friend of Dina.

Ishvar, Omprakash, and Maneck finally get off the train and head to Dina Dalai’s house. Dina greets them—she’s never seen Maneck before but knows his mother well. She begins to explain the tailoring job to Ishvar and Omprakash, which involves sewing according to patterns for a big company. They’ll get paid based on how many dresses they complete, and they have to bring their own sewing machines. Privately, after everyone leaves, Dina is glad because the sewing and the room that Maneck is renting will provide just enough money for her to make rent and stay independent.

Many of author Rohinton Mistry’s early works were set in Bombay (now Mumbai). The fact that the setting of this novel is more ambiguous (the city where much of the story takes place never gets named) reflects how the novel explores a broad spectrum of Indian life. The introduction further reinforces this idea by presenting characters from several different backgrounds. Ishvar and Omprakash are related but from different generations, while Omprakash and Maneck are a similar age but come from very different backgrounds in terms of status and wealth.



“Prime Minister” refers to Indira Gandhi (who was the real-life prime minister of India during the time when this story takes place), but the fact that her real name never appears in the novel once again helps reinforce how the novel is a broader story about Indian life and not just about the events of one time and place. The Emergency, a real time period in Indian history, is an important element of the novel’s setting, with the national turmoil both affecting and reflecting the various crises that the characters face in their personal lives.



This passage shows another example of people from different social classes meeting and misunderstanding each other. Ishvar and Omprakash think that Dina must be well off because she can afford to employ them. While it’s true that she doesn’t come from poverty to the same extent as Ishvar and Omprakash, she faces her own money problems that she tries to keep private from everyone else. With this detail, the novel shows how a higher social class can also come with the burden of having to keep up appearances.



CHAPTER 1

Before the events of the Prologue, Dina Dalai is born Dina Shroff, and her father, Dr. Shroff, is a medical doctor who devotes everything to his work. When Dina is a child, Mrs. Shroff always wants her husband to spend less time at work and sometimes tries to get Dina to convince him. Later, Dr. Shroff is hurt when his son, Nusswan (Dina's brother), goes into the import and export business instead of becoming a doctor, but he tries to hide it. Dr. Shroff is always volunteering in remote villages, and one day, he dies from a cobra bite. At the funeral, Mrs. Shroff blames Dina for not doing enough to discourage her father from being a doctor.

Nusswan is less affected by Dr. Shroff's death than Dina because he is busy at the time starting up his new business. He becomes Dina's legal guardian and takes over family finances from Mrs. Shroff. Nusswan fires their maid, claiming it is for cost-cutting reasons, but Dina suspects it's because she caught Nusswan and the maid having sex.

Nusswan believes Dr. Shroff was strict and wants to act the same way toward Dina. He restricts the amount of time when she can go see friends, particularly after he overhears Dina and her friend making fun of his teeth, which Nusswan tried to straighten when he was younger. Dina remains defiant and gets a short haircut that angers Nusswan so much that Dina begins to wonder if he's dangerous. He makes her tape her cut hair to her head until it grows back. She pretends to agree, but takes the tape off at school.

Nusswan marries three years after Dr. Shroff's death. Mrs. Shroff has become reclusive and barely responds when people talk to her. Nusswan hires a nurse, but Mrs. Shroff dies within a year. Eventually, Nusswan refuses to pay for Dina's schooling because she gets poor grades and barely passes. Nusswan's new wife, Ruby, tries to stay out of any arguments between Dina and Nusswan. Instead, Dina goes to her grandfather, who is senile but who is eventually able to understand the issue and support Dina's desire to continue with school. But by the next time her grandfather visits, he's forgotten their conversation.

The divide between Dr. Shroff and Nusswan represents two different views of India's place in the world. Dr. Shroff's willingness to go out to remote villages shows a sense of unity with fellow Indians and a desire to help people instead of making money. By contrast, Nusswan's interest in imports and exports reflects an increasing interest in international affairs as well as a stronger desire to seek profit. The fact that Dr. Shroff dies during his work suggests that his overall way of life is becoming less common as the country becomes more modern.



Nusswan's business-like way of running a household reflects how deeply he has bought into the culture of business as a whole. Still, Dina can see Nusswan's flaws and how he uses expense as a way to justify laying off the maid he had sex with. Nusswan's hypocrisy contrasts with the honest nature of his father, Dr. Shroff.



Nusswan's insistence on controlling Dina's behavior shows how in spite of his interest in modernity and international business, he also values tradition. For him, Dina's short hair goes against tradition, and he is willing to go to extreme and illogical lengths, like taping Dina's hair back on, in order to uphold tradition. The absurdity of Nusswan's actions show the futility of trying to go back to the past.



This passage shows how in spite of Dina's middle-class upbringing, she still struggles to achieve independence for herself because of her status as a woman. Ruby deals with the limited power of women by becoming passive and avoiding arguments, but Dina is too passionate to do that. The fact that Dina's grandfather promises to help her and then forgets is the first of many broken promises that come up in this book, often between the Indian government and its people.



When Dina turns 18, Nusswan starts inviting his friends over to their house as potential future husbands for Dina. Dina hates all of them because they remind her of Nusswan. Although Dina and Ruby sometimes argue, they eventually learn to work together. Ruby and Nusswan have a son named Xerxes. Dina begins saving up to take bus rides to the library, where she listens to records in the music room. Through reading magazines, she learns about free concerts and starts attending them.

At concerts, Dina is sometimes more entertained by the people around her than the music. At one of them, she meets a man named Rustom Dalai. He says he's noticed her at several concerts. The two of them talk, and Rustom eventually starts taking the bus instead of cycling so that he'll see Dina more often. A year and a half later, Dina tells Nusswan and Ruby that she's getting married. They're surprised and worried that Rustom isn't one of the young men they've picked.

Rustom comes over to meet Nusswan and Ruby. Nusswan is angry afterwards and offended that Rustom didn't bring fancy gifts like gold jewelry. But after thinking it over, he calms down and even becomes glad that Dina picked someone who is a "worse" prospect than any of his friends he tried to set her up with. The wedding is a small, simple one. Afterwards, Nusswan hosts a party at the Shroff house and brings out lots of Scotch whiskey. Ruby, pregnant with a second child, goes around to greet everyone.

After the party, Dina and Rustom go back to his place, while Nusswan takes care of clean-up. Rustom has taken a week off of work, but they can't afford a vacation for their honeymoon. The next morning, Rustom shows Dina his violin. He then shows her how he changed the engraving on the door to read "Mr. and Mrs. Rustom K. Dalai." Rent on the building is still in Rustom's father's name, even though he's been dead many years, but Rustom says they're protected by local rent laws.

Dina begins to rearrange Rustom's house. For their first wedding anniversary, in 1951, they go to see a film. It's a grim submarine film, so the next year, they see a new Bing Crosby movie. For their third anniversary, they invite Nusswan, Ruby, and their two kids, Xerxes and Zarir. Because they don't have an icebox, Rustom takes his bicycle to go get ice cream. He takes a long time, and eventually Dina and Nusswan decide they have to go out to the shop with the ice cream.

This passage develops the idea that, in spite of her middle-class life, Dina struggles to find freedom, as Nusswan and Ruby continue to try to influence her life. The library and specifically the music in it help her to get away from her responsibilities at home, showing how art and culture can have a freeing effect on a person. Against Nusswan's wishes, Dina shows a desire to expand her horizons beyond just the household.



Rustom comes from a world of culture and music that Dina associates with freedom. Within the world Dina lives in, marriage is one of the few possibilities that would allow her to escape the influence of Nusswan. The fact that Nusswan and Ruby don't trust Dina's judgement about Rustom shows once again how they try to limit Dina's independence.



Nusswan continues to show that he values material things, like gold jewelry, without taking notice of Rustom's positive qualities. The Scotch whiskey that Nusswan serves everyone after the wedding is another example of his contradictory character and how he supports "traditional" Indian values in his household but has alcohol imported from around the world. He doesn't seem to hold himself to the same standards of traditional behavior as he does Dina.



Rustom can't provide Dina with the money for a honeymoon, but he shows that he cares for her by making the effort to change the engraving on the door so quickly. The reference to Rustom's complicated rent situation (where his father's name is on the lease) is an early hint of how competitive housing is in the city where the novel takes place, which will affect the lives of many of the main characters.



The fact that Dina and Rustom celebrate their anniversary with a movie (which is relatively inexpensive) suggests that they continue to live humbly. Still, their marriage seems to be happy, with Rustom listening to Dina's complaints about the grim submarine movie they see and going instead to see a Bing Crosby movie (which were typically light-hearted musicals).



When Dina and Nusswan get to the shop, there's a crowd. They learn that a lorry (truck) driver hit someone, and the victim went to the hospital but seemed dead. Rustom's destroyed bicycle is nearby. Dina and Nusswan walk home, and Xerxes and Zarir wonder where the ice cream is. Nusswan is impressed with how calm Dina remains.

After Rustom's funeral, Dina stays for a while with Nusswan and Ruby. Nusswan pays Dina's rent at Rustom's old apartment, expecting Dina to one day remarry. A year later, the mourning period ends, and Dina is still living with Nusswan. Whenever he brings up the topic of remarriage, she gets irritated. The two of them argue so much that Dina finally decides to move back to her old apartment, upsetting Xerxes and Zarir.

After moving back to her old apartment, Dina goes to see Rustom's uncle Darab, seeking to join the sewing business with Rustom's aunt Shirin. Eventually, she takes over the whole business from Shirin, who is getting too old to see well. Shirin warns Dina to always have a witness when taking the measurements of bachelors to prevent gossip from spreading. Dina remembers this advice when doing a job for a bachelor named Fredoon. Within a few years, both Shirin and Darab die.

Some of Nusswan's relatives start to blame him for Dina leaving. These relatives start suggesting money-making ideas to Dina, including a haircutting business that never gets off the ground. In the time since Shirin's death, Dina has become Fredoon's lover. One day when they're having sex, it rains, and Dina thinks of Rustom. Fredoon is disappointed that Dina seems so disinterested in him, but he keeps trying to impress Dina with new sexual techniques. Dina doesn't tell Nusswan about Fredoon.

On the 12th anniversary of Rustom's death, Dina gets the idea to sell his old violin. She heads back to the music store but finds that its window has been shattered by protestors claiming that South Indians are coming to town and "stealing" jobs from locals. She finds that the violin isn't worth much because she didn't store it properly. Six months later, she gets a delivery: Rustom's bicycle. It has rusted heavily during 12 years in storage.

Rustom's bicycle, which used to represent freedom and independence, has now seemingly played a part in his death. Rustom's death suggests how hostile the city is toward people who try to be free. Nusswan once again seems to misunderstand his sister, interpreting her shock as calm.



Dina's decision to move to her own apartment, even without a husband anymore, reflects her growing desire to achieve independence—even if that means going against tradition. While Nusswan shows kindness to Dina by paying for the apartment, he continues to try to control her, not understanding why she might still feel grief even after the traditional mourning period.



Shirin's warning to Dina—that she should be careful when taking the measurements of a man, to avoid rumors from starting—is another example of how it is difficult for a woman to become independent in this society. Even the suspicion of doing something wrong could be enough to ruin her reputation and make it more difficult for her to earn a living.



By having a relationship with Fredoon outside of marriage, Dina further shows how she is willing to reject Nusswan's ideas about tradition. Still, she finds that in the case of Fredoon, even when she disobeys Nusswan's traditional wishes, she still struggles to be happy. This passage explores how Dina is searching for something deeper in her life than the sex that motivates Fredoon and the money that motivates Nusswan.



The novel explores not just the divide between India and the rest of the world, but also divisions within the country. The narration never specifies which city the novel takes place in, but most of author Mistry's previous works are set in Bombay (now Mumbai), which is in the western part of the country. The decay of Rustom's violin symbolizes the corrosive effect that Dina's grief has had on her life.



Dina sees the reappearance of the bicycle so soon after she sold the violin as a sign. She stops seeing Fredoon and starts making plans to remarry. Zenobia, Dina's friend, helps her get a more lucrative sewing job working for Mrs. Gupta, the wife of a manager at a large textile company. To make more money, she also plans to take in a boarder at her house. This brings things up to the point where Maneck, Ishvar, and Omprakash all arrive together at Dina's door.

The decomposed violin and the broken bicycle both remind Dina of the consequences of inaction. This gives her the motivation to leave Fredoon, who has never been able to satisfy her in spite of his best efforts. The chapter ends on a hopeful note, with Dina making plans to change her life, although the chapter as a whole reveals how Dina isn't as confident and comfortable as she seemed to Omprakash and Ishvar when they first met her.



CHAPTER 2

Dina goes to Mrs. Gupta's textile warehouse and tells her that she's found two tailors. Mrs. Gupta is happy because Prime Minister has put several of her opponents in jail. She believes in discipline. Dina takes the materials back to her house to set up her business. She worries whether the Emergency will stop Ishvar and Omprakash from getting to the warehouse. They do eventually arrive by taxi, with sewing machines that they bought on a three-year installment plan. Dina oversees them and resists the urge to join in, trying to stay in the role of supervisor.

Mrs. Gupta is wealthy and so her support for the Prime Minister seems to reflect how the Prime Minister's policies have been beneficial for the wealthy. Mrs. Gupta doesn't care about Prime Minister jailing political prisoners, showing her selfishness and lack of regard for the lives of others. Meanwhile, by contrast, Ishvar and Omprakash have to take out three-year loans just to get the equipment they need for their jobs, meaning they live very different lives from Mrs. Gupta.



Ishvar and Omprakash keep coming back to Dina's house for work, but they're sometimes late due to train problems. Dina notices how thin Omprakash is and suggests seeing a doctor, but Ishvar says he's fine and they have no money for that. One day, while Ishvar and Omprakash are working alone, a stranger outside says that despite the padlock on the front, he knows an illegal business is going on inside. This is how Ishvar and Omprakash learn that Dina is locking them inside.

Omprakash's thinness is a sign of both how scarce food is for him and his uncle as well as how people in poverty often can't afford to see doctors. The padlock on the door suggests that, as much as Dina wants to achieve independence from Nusswan, she ends up literally imprisoning Ishvar and Omprakash. The padlock perhaps also represents Dina's reluctance to open herself up emotionally after the death of Rustom.



The stranger outside leaves a letter for Dina. Omprakash begins to complain to Ishvar that Dina is cheating them and they could do the work without her. But Ishvar says they have no shop to work out of. He urges patience and convinces Omprakash not to open the letter for Dina. Dina comes back and explains that the stranger was probably the rent collector (Ibrahim)—she is pleased that Ishvar and Omprakash stayed hidden from him. Omprakash remains annoyed with Dina for locking them in, but Ishvar tries to smooth things over.

This passage explores one of the main differences between Omprakash and Ishvar. While Omprakash remains skeptical of authority, including Dina, Ishvar places greater trust in authority and in the idea that things will work out in the end. While Ishvar may at times seem naïve, his life story (revealed later) shows that he is well aware of how some authority figures can misuse their power. The novel doesn't necessarily take a side in the argument, showing how both Ishvar's trust and Omprakash's skepticism can each have benefits and downsides.



Ibrahim the rent collector comes back the next day to demand a reply from Dina to his letter. He is old and has become very invested in his job, spying on and intimidating tenants for the sake of the landlord. He always carries a folder with him that is full of documents. He often seeks fortune-tellers in the market to try to calm his anxieties. Ibrahim has continued at his work even after his wife and daughter died of tuberculosis.

While Dina has had to padlock in Ishvar and Omprakash to try to attain freedom for herself, Ibrahim represents an even more extreme version of this, going out of his way to harass people for the sake of his boss. Still, the fact that Ibrahim is full of anxiety and that he is grieving deaths in his family suggests that perhaps there is more to his character than his work would suggest.



Ibrahim arrives at Dina's to ask about the letter from the landlord. She hasn't opened it yet, so she opens it then and discovers that it's a letter warning her that if she continues to run a business in her home, she'll be evicted. Dina decides to continue with the business anyway, warning Omprakash and Ishvar to be discreet.

Dina's decision to keep running an illegal business even after being warned not to reflects how desperate her situation is. The novel raises the question of what makes something legal or illegal, showing how in India during this time, the law does not apply equally to everyone, with the most vulnerable often facing harsher penalties.



CHAPTER 3

Back in Omprakash and Ishvar's home village, their family used to be tanners and leather-workers. But before then, before Omprakash is even born, Ishvar becomes apprenticed to become a tailor at age 12. His father, Dukhi Mochi, is a Chamaar (a group of people in the caste system considered "untouchable" during this era), and people consider him mad for abandoning the traditional Chamaar trade of leather-working.

The caste system is a system of social hierarchy that has existed in various forms in India going back to ancient times. As a Chamaar, Dukhi and his family are part of the very bottom level of this caste system. Caste is not specifically based on wealth, although this chapter shows how people like Dukhi struggle to make a decent living due to the social ostracization they face.



When Dukhi Mochi turns 18, he marries a Chamaar girl named Roopa. Roopa has to steal for them to have enough food, particularly after the birth of Ishvar. One time while stealing oranges, she is raped by a guard. She tells Dukhi, but then acts the next morning like nothing happened, and so Dukhi does too.

Similar to Dina's story, Roopa's experience in this passage depicts how women had to bottle up their feelings even under extreme circumstances. While Nusswan expected Dina to get over her grief for Rustom, Roopa now feels that she can't speak with anyone about her rape—even her husband.



Two years after the birth of Ishvar, Roopa and Dukhi have a second son, Narayan. People become envious of their two sons—some families will kill their newborns if they turn out to be daughters. A rumor gets started that the children aren't really Dukhi's and he kidnapped them. Upper-caste people in the village start flogging the Chamaar more, and Dukhi gets punished for falling asleep while he is supposed to be watching a herd of goats.

The killing of female children shows once again how even from birth, women and girls face sometimes deadly challenges. The fact that people begin to resent Dukhi and his family just for having sons shows how competition can lead to animosity between different social groups—and how this animosity can lead to violence. When Dukhi falls asleep on the job, it suggests that perhaps he isn't fully awake to the dangers that upper-caste people pose to him—or perhaps he's just too exhausted to do anything about it.



When Ishvar is old enough, Dukhi starts to teach him the leather trade, then later the same for Narayan. The year that the boys are 10 and 8, there's a lot of rain. One day, while grinding chilis in a giant pestle for a Thakur (feudal lord), Dukhi accidentally drops the pestle on his foot, injuring his foot, breaking the pestle, and severely angering the Thakur. Dukhi goes home and hits Roopa when she tries to ask about his injured foot. Two days later, he admits what happened and curses all upper-caste people.

One day on his way to work, Dukhi notices a crowd gathering. Some leaders of the Indian National Congress are visiting, and a speaker gives a speech about throwing the British out of the country. The speaker then goes on to say that there's an even greater problem within Indian society—the idea that certain people are “untouchable.” The speaker believes no one is untouchable.

Dukhi continues to hear of bad things happening to the “untouchables” in his village. Roopa worries that Ishvar or Narayan will get into trouble when they go off on their free time, but they seem to know their place in society. One day, when the local schoolhouse is empty, Ishvar and Narayan sneak inside and play with the chalk, putting it on their foreheads like Brahmins. They get caught, and the schoolmaster canes them.

When Dukhi hears of Ishvar and Narayan getting caught at the school, he goes to Pandit Lalluram, who has a reputation for being fair and solving local problems. Dukhi tells Pandit Lalluram that his two sons were beaten unfairly. Pandit Lalluram explains that every caste of person follows their own dharma (religious concept similar to duty or way in life), and Ishvar and Narayan have upset this balance by going into an upper-caste school. Dukhi leaves disappointed and says Pandit Lalluram should instead be called Shit-Eating Brahmin.

Dukhi's discontent with the caste system motivates him to go against tradition and have Ishvar and Narayan become apprentices to Ashraf, the tailor. Dukhi tells his sons to change their last name from Mochi to Darji to hide their identities. The two boys leave their village and go to live in Ashraf's shop. The two boys begin to learn the skills to be a tailor, but Narayan misses home and cries at night. Ashraf tries to reassure him, saying he can be like a father.

This passage shows how violence can spread. Although Dukhi has been kind to Roopa before, after the Thakur gets angry with Dukhi, he takes out his anger by hitting Roopa. The injury to Dukhi's foot symbolizes how as a Chamaar he has no social mobility and he has to put himself at risk just to avoid angering those in higher social positions than he is.



From the 1800s until 1947, much of India was a colony of Britain. As the speaker at the event that Dukhi sees points out, it would be hypocritical to demand freedom from the British but to refuse freedom to people within India just because they are “untouchable.” Although over the course of the novel, laws pass to protect so-called “untouchable” people, such laws did not always lead to enforcement in the real world.



Brahmins sometimes put white markings on their foreheads (called a tilak) that is a symbol of piety. Ishvar and Narayan get punished because they don't know their place, acting like they're part of the highest caste in society (Brahmins) when in fact they're part of one of the lowest castes (Chamaars). Although they can't attend school, the school ends up teaching them an important lesson about their place in society anyway.



Pandit is a title that usually signifies a Hindu scholar or priest. Dukhi thinks that because Pandit Lalluram has such a wise reputation, he may be able to help with Dukhi's current situation. But what Dukhi fails to realize is that because Pandit Lalluram is a Brahmin (at the top of the caste system), he sees things differently than Dukhi and believes in maintaining a status quo that keeps people like Dukhi's family at the bottom.



Just as Dina tried to go against the traditional expectations of a woman in her position, Dukhi tries to go against society's expectations with how he helps his sons get involved in a new career. The role that Ashraf plays for the two boys, as a surrogate father, introduces the theme that family is not always strictly about blood relations.



Roopa complains while Ishvar and Narayan are gone but is happy when they come back to the village for a visit. They look healthy and are happy to demonstrate some of their new skills by measuring their parents. The two boys go back to the apprenticeship, each time staying away for three months, then coming back for a one-week visit.

When Ishvar and Narayan are 18 and 16, they're near the end of their training. Ashraf has had several more children. Narayan wants to go back to their village to set up a sewing shop, but Ishvar wants to go somewhere with more opportunities. Meanwhile riots break out nearby over independence. Ashraf convinces the boys to stay in his village because the violence hasn't reached there yet. Dukhi is disappointed that his boys won't be returning. In his village, the landlords are taking advantage of rumors that Muslims have been attacking Hindus, trying to use this as an excuse to dispossess Muslims.

Eventually the violence reaches Ashraf's village, with Muslims being killed and their businesses destroyed. Ashraf, who is Muslim, makes plans to leave with his family. Narayan and Ishvar don't want him to leave, but Ashraf says they'll always be family, even when they're apart. But when several local business owners hear of Ashraf's plan to leave, they try to convince him to stay, promising to protect him and his family if necessary. Ashraf makes plans to change the name of his business from Muzaffar Tailoring Company to something that sounds more Hindu.

Ashraf and his family get rid of any evidence that they're Muslim and start posing as Hindus. But one night, a crowd of about 20 to 30 men shows up outside the shop and claims that they've heard it's owned by a Muslim. Ishvar and Narayan go to meet the crowd, claiming that their father owns "Krishna Tailors," and he's out of town visiting a sick relative. One of the men makes the boys take off their pants to inspect their foreskins. Eventually, the crowd goes away.

Ashraf says he and his family owe their lives to Ishvar and Narayan. Although he can't really afford it, he wants to keep them as paid assistants. Eventually, only Ishvar stays with Ashraf, and Narayan goes back to Dukhi and Roopa's village. Narayan begins to build a name for himself as a tailor. He decides that he will sew for anyone, even people of the lowest castes.

Ishvar and Narayan are just two of the many characters in the novel who struggle with both wanting to be with their families but needing to go away in search of economic opportunities. Earning a living, particularly at the poverty level, involves making sacrifices in this novel.



This passage is one of the first signs of the religious disagreements that sometimes lurk beneath the surface of Indian society. Although independence from the British could be a cause to bring people together, instead it leads to violence among Hindus and Muslims. As is often the case, this violence also has a financial motivation behind it, with some people taking advantage of how the riots put Muslim business owners in a vulnerable position.



Although the novel explores the dark side of the religious divisions within India, this passage also provides some hope by showing how Narayan and Ishvar are able to look beyond religious divisions and stand up for the Muslim Ashraf. The novel celebrates people who can think for themselves and help the people near them, rather than upholding the status quo or going along with a mob.



Krishna is one of the major gods in Hinduism and an avatar of the god Vishnu. The men force Ishvar and Narayan to remove their pants because they want to see whether or not they are circumcised. Circumcision (removing the foreskin from the penis) is common today globally and has long been part of Islam and Judaism. By contrast, Hinduism generally discourages circumcision, so by showing their foreskins, Ishvar and Narayan prove that they are Hindu. The mob's demand that the boys take off their pants shows how intrusive and threatening religious bigotry can be.



Just as Narayan and Ishvar grew apart from their parents, as the two boys age, they start to stake out different life paths for themselves. Narayan seems to be more interested in going home and upholding the old traditions, whereas Ishvar seems to have a greater desire to go out and explore the rest of the world.



After two years, Narayan saves up enough money to build a hut by Roopa and Dukhi. Roopa complains that he's abandoning her but soon becomes proud of the hut. Meanwhile, Ishvar gets promoted to being Ashraf's partner. Together, the two of them let Dukhi retire so that they can provide for their parents. While many in the village are happy for the sons' success, some upper-caste people, including Thakur Dharamsi, begin to feel resentful.

Roopa and Dukhi start looking for potential daughters-in-law. When Ishvar doesn't seem interested, they start by trying to find someone for Narayan. They arrange for Narayan to marry Radha, a girl from a nearby village, whom Narayan eventually approves of. Right before the wedding, Thakur Dharamsi forces the village musicians to cancel, and so Dukhi has to find replacements.

Narayan and Radha give birth to Omprakash. They go on to have three daughters, but only two (Leela and Rekha) survive. Narayan teaches Omprakash to read, and shortly after Omprakash's fifth birthday, Narayan takes him to the tannery where the Chamaars work. Narayan tries to force Omprakash to help with the work, and Omprakash cries, even after they go home. Radha protests that Omprakash doesn't have to learn such dirty work, but Narayan is determined to keep taking Omprakash back.

Omprakash learns tanning for three years, but at age eight, he gets sent to learn tailoring from his uncle Ishvar. The place where Ishvar lives is bigger and the school there now accepts people of all castes. One day, on a visit to Dukhi, Narayan complains that despite everything that has changed in India—*independence and laws banning the concept of untouchability*—upper-caste people still look down on people like him. Dukhi says politicians like to pass laws more than enforce them. During elections, people like Thakur Dharamsi oversee the voting process and essentially determine the votes.

Two years later—it's been 16 years since his wedding—Narayan goes to the next election and requests to personally see his ballot so that he can vote. Thakur Dharamsi comes over to see what the problem is. Narayan says it's his right to vote, but Thakur Dharamsi just apprehends Narayan and two others and starts flogging them. Eventually, Thakur Dharamsi hangs them and displays the bodies in the village square.

Roopa's complaints are humorous, since she suggests that even a hut right next door is too far away for her son to be, showing what a protective parent she is. Dukhi's retirement leads to a reversal of roles, with the sons he once cared for now taking care of him instead. This reversal shows how Ishvar and Narayan are moving out of boyhood and apprenticeship into becoming adults.



In Hinduism, Radha is the lover of Krishna (the god that Narayan renamed Ashraf's store after). Ishvar's own lack of interest in marriage at this time is different from how he feels later in the novel, setting up his character's development and his feelings about family over the course of the novel.



Narayan chose tradition by returning to the village where he grew up, and like many traditional characters in the story (particularly men), Narayan is very strict with his family as he forces Omprakash to learn a difficult trade at a young age. Narayan is even stricter than his own father, who despite learning tanning at age five himself, tried to hold back on Narayan learning the trade of tanning at such a young age.



Ishvar's different living situation contrasts with how his personality has also begun to differ from Narayan's. The fact that he lives in a larger town with a school that is starting to accept people of all castes reflects how Ishvar is more open to the modern world and to new ideas. Dukhi's comment about how politicians prefer passing laws over enforcing them is a theme that runs throughout the book and shows how elite members of society often position themselves above the law and break their promises to the common people.



Even though Narayan advised Omprakash in the ways of a Chamaar, to try to avoid displeasing members of the upper castes, Narayan himself can't resist the urge to speak up when he sees the injustice of Thakur Dharamsi and the rigged elections. In spite of his prior caution, Narayan ends up dead, providing yet another example in the story of the cruel role that chance and timing can play in a person's life, as well as illustrating how disposably some upper-caste people treat members of the lower castes.



Thakur Dharamsi continues to harass Narayan's family, blaming Dukhi for his son's behavior. He gathers Dukhi, Roopa, Radha, Leela, and Rekha and ties them up in their house. He shows them Narayan's body, then lights the whole house on fire, killing all of them. When Ishvar hears the news, he reports it to the police, but they investigate it and accuse him of lying. Ashraf tries to help, but the police won't listen to him either.

Thakur Dharamsi's actions show both the extent of his cruelty as well as how the laws are tilted in favor of powerful men like him, as opposed to Chamaars. When Ishvar and Ashraf try to contact the police, they realize that even the official justice system of the country seems to be rigged against lower-class people like them.



Omprakash talks of gathering an army of Chamaars to seek revenge. Ashraf tells him to be careful, and Ashraf and Ishvar each try to think of ways to stop Omprakash from seeking vengeance.

Omprakash shows an early example of his rebellious streak, which remains a part of his character throughout the novel. By contrast, Ishvar, who once was the one eager to leave his home village, now finds himself cautioning Omprakash to act more circumspectly.



A year after the murders, a store opens in town that sells ready-made clothing, which shrinks Ashraf's list of customers. Eventually, business gets so slow that Ishvar talks of potentially going with Omprakash into a bigger city, where the factories make ready-made clothes. Ashraf sends them to see his friend Nawaz.

The ready-made clothing store is yet another example of the new era of modernization and industrialization in India that these characters live in. The decline of small stores like Ashraf's shows how these big businesses have made everyday life more impersonal and made it harder for less privileged people to earn a living.



When Ishvar and Omprakash go to see Nawaz, he acts like he wasn't expecting them. Ishvar tries to make the best of the situation although Omprakash is sometimes offended by the lack of hospitality. Nawaz tells them he doesn't have enough work for them. One day, they overhear Nawaz talking with his wife about how he's trying to make his two guests leave. He hits her when she argues.

Nawaz's relative indifference toward Ishvar and Omprakash represents the attitudes that many middle- and upper-class Indians in the story have when they see the suffering of people in lower classes. When Nawaz hits his wife, it's yet another example in the novel of the casual violence that so many of the female characters live in fear of.



Ishvar and Omprakash manage to find a meager amount of work with another tailor in town. After four months, Nawaz starts insisting they find more work, and Ishvar takes a job helping to make leather for a cobbler. Finally, Nawaz tells Ishvar and Omprakash that he ran into a rich lady named Dina who needs two tailors.

Although Nawaz helps Ishvar and Omprakash by giving them a place to stay, he does so grudgingly, out of a sense of obligation to Ashraf rather than out of compassion. Nawaz represents the transactional way that people sometimes act in the big city, where people put their own needs first.



Nawaz begins insisting that Ishvar and Omprakash should live somewhere else. He shows them some options, but Ishvar says they don't have enough money left for a rental deposit. Nawaz angrily agrees to pay the deposit if Ishvar and Omprakash go on to pay the rest of the rent. They learn that their new place is owned by the city and their "landlord" is just someone who bribes local officials.

Nawaz pays money to help Ishvar and Omprakash with a rental deposit but only so that he can get them out of his own house. In spite of his seemingly generous actions, Nawaz ultimately acts for selfish reasons, showing hypocrisy. Ishvar and Omprakash's new living arrangement, which exists in a legal gray area, is a sign of how competitive and complex housing has become in the city.



CHAPTER 4

After Omprakash and Ishvar have left Ashraf but before they start their new job with Dina, they live in the slum that Nawaz picked for them. Omprakash wants to go back to Ashraf, but Ishvar urges him to make the best of their current situation. He talks about soon finding a wife for Omprakash. The two of them learn that in the slum where they live, water only runs rarely, and people get angry if you take too long collecting it. A stranger named Rajaram introduces Ishvar and Omprakash to some of the customs in the area, like how the best place to empty your bowels is the railroad tracks.

Rajaram continues to give advice to Ishvar and Omprakash, telling them to get a ration card for food and allowing them to borrow his stove. The three of them spend the evening talking, with Ishvar and Omprakash telling Rajaram about their past at Muzaffar Tailoring Company. Rajaram says he used to be a barber but now collects hair, which can be sold to foreign countries. He shows them some hair samples, and they talk about how Dina has such nice hair.

Omprakash gets distracted when he sees a girl carrying firewood. He saw her earlier when she was collecting water. He hears someone call her name and learns that it's Shanti.

Later, Ishvar and Omprakash go to the rations office but find that the boss is away on his meditation break. When he gets back, they fill out a form for him. But the Rations Officer informs them that their address is in a "jhopadpatti" (slum), meaning they aren't eligible for rations. Still, he tells them they can become eligible if they get a vasectomy. Ishvar tries to lie about having a vasectomy but doesn't have a certificate to prove it. He doesn't want one and especially doesn't want Omprakash to have one. They leave.

Outside the rations office, Ishvar and Omprakash meet a man who calls himself a "facilitator" and says he can get them a rations card. He explains that the Rations Officer gets a promotion if he fills his quota of sterilizations. But Ishvar and Omprakash don't have enough money for the Facilitator's offer.

This passage shows the harshness and precariousness of life in a slum, but it also shows how difficult situations can bring people together. Although Rajaram has much less than Nawaz to offer to Ishvar and Omprakash, he shows much more generosity with the little that he has—which is mainly just knowledge about local customs. The lack of water, which is necessary for life, shows how difficult it is to survive in the slums but also how people adapt and find ways to survive through ingenuity.



Rajaram's transition from a barber to a black-market seller of hair is yet another example of how Indian society has been changing. Being a barber is a service that helps people in a local community, whereas selling hair is about taking a local "product" and selling it to foreign countries. In spite of India's independence, many like Rajaram find themselves forced to look internationally to make a living.



Om Shanti is a mantra about seeking peace. The way that Om (Omprakash's nickname) and Shanti go together seems to suggest fate, but the harsh reality of life in the city should make readers suspect it won't be that simple.



This passage introduces the government policy during this era of "family planning," which often involved sterilization of people from the lower classes. Ishvar and Omprakash learn that the government seems be hostile to their own survival—either they can try to live without a reliable source of food, or they can get a vasectomy and give up the chance to have children. This once again shows how people of lower castes faced discrimination, even after laws passed to protect them.



This passage once again explores the idea of selfishness, showing how the Rations Officer has an economic motivation to increase the number of sterilizations. The Facilitator similarly has the ability to help Ishvar and Omprakash, but he'll only do so if they pay him.



Ishvar and Omprakash go to their first 10-hour day of work for Dina and come back exhausted. They see people on the train jumping off early because they don't have tickets and police are chasing after them. Because of all the confusion at the station, they are late getting back to Rajaram for dinner. Rajaram explains that such raids by police to discover people without tickets are uncommon—people seldom get arrested because the jails are already too full with Prime Minister's enemies.

The tickets on the train provide another example in the city of how so many people can only survive by trying to live outside of the law. Although police won't get involved to help with the deaths of Ishvar and Omprakash's family, they still make a show of arresting people who are too poor to afford train tickets. The inability of so many people to afford train tickets is yet another example in the story of how poverty restricts mobility.



The local slumlord keeps adding more huts to the neighborhood. During monsoon season, Ishvar and Omprakash's roof leaks. They continue to have dinners with Rajaram, and one evening he surprises them by asking for a loan of 10 rupees. That evening, they hear Rajaram in his hut having sex.

The implication in this passage is that Rajaram may have taken the money that Ishvar and Omprakash lent him in order to pay a sex worker. This passage shows how even at the poverty level, people have needs and desires that go beyond basic survival.



The next morning, Omprakash looks into renting a bicycle. He seems to really enjoy the freedom of a bicycle, but Ishvar can't help worrying about him. Eventually, Omprakash convinces Ishvar to hop on too, and they take the bicycle to Dina's, where they hide it.

Rustom's death has already shown how the freedom and independence that comes with riding a bicycle in the city can also be dangerous. Omprakash's disregard of these dangers reflects his rebellious nature compared to Ishvar's more cautious personality.



While they're working that day, Omprakash waits for the right moment before all of a sudden stabbing himself in the finger with his scissors, getting blood on a dress they're working on. Dina panics, trying to save the dress by soaking it in water and calling Omprakash careless. Omprakash says he needs to see a doctor. Reluctantly, Dina lets him leave. She looks forward to when Maneck finally moves in and she'll have a more stable source of income.

Omprakash senses that, as much as he and Ishvar need Dina as a source of income, Dina also depends on the two of them to keep doing work for her. Omprakash's decision to make himself bleed with scissors shows the lengths that he is willing to go to just for the possibility of gaining more independence.



Dina leaves in a taxi to go see Mrs. Gupta. Instead of going to a doctor, Omprakash uses his bicycle to follow her. Along the way he gets hit by a car, and people around think he's seriously injured. He gets up and is surprised when a chauffeur in the car gives him 50 rupees. Someone on the pavement tells him that he could've earned even more if he'd pretended to be more injured and stayed down longer.

Although Omprakash displayed some craftiness by faking an excuse to see a doctor, this stranger who gives Omprakash advice reveals that surviving in the city often requires even greater levels of ingenuity. For Omprakash, it's arguably more profitable to risk hurting himself in an accident than to do a normal job, showing how the financial incentives in the city are warped.



When Omprakash gets back, Ishvar thinks he's discovered the company that Dina works for, but in fact, Omprakash is just happy because he spent some of the money he obtained on candy. Meanwhile, Dina makes preparations for Maneck to move in. She gives him her bedroom and moves into one that's a lot shabbier.

Like Rajaram paying for sex, Omprakash buying candy shows how even in poverty where money is tight, people still want things that aren't strictly necessary for survival. Meanwhile, Dina's willingness to sacrifice her own room for Maneck shows how far she's willing to go to try to preserve her independence.



CHAPTER 5

Maneck moves into Dina's house. Although she tries to be a good host, he can see signs of her money problems everywhere in the house. Zenobia was the one who originally found Maneck for Dina, and Dina didn't actually remember Maneck's mother, Aban Sodawalla (later Aban Kohlah) very well.

Maneck's family used to be wealthy. His father, Farokh Kohlah, owned a lot of land. In a flashback, when Maneck is five years old, he helps his parents in a shop they own. The shop is known for having a special soft-drink formula that has been in the family for generations, Kohlah's Cola. Maneck starts school and has a fairly happy childhood. A girl named Suraiya lives nearby, and she and Maneck sometimes go into the bushes to show each other their genitals. When they get caught, Farokh decides to send Maneck to boarding school.

While at boarding school, Maneck often misses home. When he comes home, he tries to get out of boarding school, but Farokh forces him to stay in. He tries to remind Maneck that school won't last forever and that it's important to get an education. When Maneck goes back, things are more bearable, and three years pass without any problems.

On a vacation home in his third year of boarding school, Maneck gets to run the family shop for a couple days while Farokh and Aban are away for a wedding. Maneck makes some changes to the shop that he thinks will improve it and make it neater, but when Farokh comes back, he's angry that Maneck didn't do exactly as he was told. Aban later explains to Farokh how he hurt Maneck's feelings, and from then on, Farokh tries to involve Maneck more in the shop.

The mountains around Maneck's home become increasingly developed, with new roads changing the natural landscape. Farokh is dismayed to see the land he owns getting polluted. Maneck begins to act more distantly toward his parents when he's home. Farokh starts taking long walks to appreciate all the trees and rocks that still remain, and people begin to spread rumors that he's gone mad and is talking to nature.

A chaiwalla is a person who sells tea, so Sodawalla is a fitting and perhaps humorous last name for someone who marries into a family with a soda-selling empire. Maneck's judgement of Dina shows how important it is to keep up appearances of social class.



Maneck's family's last name of Kohla is a play on "cola"—more soda-based wordplay. The connection of people's names to their businesses shows once again how important money is in this society. In spite of coming from more money than most of the other characters in the novel, Maneck begins to struggle with a similar generational divide between him and his parents, showing how some issues are universal across class.



Like Ishvar and Narayan, Maneck learns more about the world by moving away from the home where he grew up. At boarding school, Maneck begins the journey toward starting a new career that will potentially take him even further away from Farokh and his store. For Maneck, moving forward and maturing means letting go of his past and his old home.



Like many characters in the story, Maneck wants to do things differently than his parents. For Maneck, his father's way of running the shop is old fashioned and behind the times. Although Farokh at first appears to be yet another character obsessed with maintaining tradition, he eventually feels bad for not listening to Maneck. Both Maneck and his father show nuance and ability to compromise, suggesting that in the conflict between tradition and the new ways, each side has some benefits.



The changing landscape is yet another sign of the increasing industrialization of India during this time period. One of the consequences of this shift toward industry is an increase in pollution. Farokh seems to have taken the natural world for granted, but the prospect of losing it causes him to appreciate it more.



On vacation before his final term at boarding school, Maneck continues to argue with his parents, specifically with Farokh over Maneck's ideas to expand the store with marketing. The new road has made Farokh try to cling to the elements of the past that he still can. Big companies try to buy the rights to Kohlah's Cola, but Farokh refuses. Instead of changing the business, Farokh tries to get Maneck set up in a different business.

Once again, a clash between generations also becomes a clash about different economic ideals. Like Nusswan, Maneck wants to embrace international business, but Farokh is determined to preserve the old ways—perhaps especially after he sees the toll that big industry is taking on the local landscape.



Maneck finishes boarding school but now makes plans to go away to college. On his journey to college, Maneck meets a proofreader and is surprised at how interesting the man is—more like a poet than a proofreader. The man has a sore throat because he spent most of his early years working silently in an office, then later started writing speeches and political slogans, which required him to shout and made him lose his voice. The man says his name is Vasantrya Valmik.

Maneck's observation that Mr. Valmik seems like a poet is in part a joke about how his name is similar to Valmiki, the poet traditionally credited as the author of the Ramayana (an epic text that is important in Hinduism). The evolution of Valmik's career—from a man who quietly proofreads to a man who loses his voice because he has to write speeches—reflects recent changes in society and how politics are increasingly becoming a part of people's daily lives.



It takes Maneck 36 hours to get from his home to college. He says goodbye to Vasantrya Valmik and takes a taxi to his college hostel. At the hostel, a warden tells him the many rules, like always keeping his room locked. In his room, he finds and kills three cockroaches. The noise brings over his neighbor, Avinash, who helps him fumigate. Maneck and Avinash play a game of draughts (also called checkers). Maneck learns that Avinash is on a scholarship and that his father operates machinery in a textile mill, where he got tuberculosis.

The cockroaches in Maneck's room suggest that even someone from a middle-class family like himself has to deal with squalor when living in a big city, where housing is at a premium. Still, just as Omprakash and Ishvar get help from Rajaram, Avinash shows Maneck how a hostile environment can actually bring people together. Avinash's background—that he's on a scholarship and that his father works in a textile mill—suggests that he comes from a lower-class background.



Maneck and Avinash continue to spend time together over the next two weeks, with Avinash teaching Maneck how to play chess. Maneck learns that Avinash won a chess tournament at his old school. In the middle of one lesson in the dining hall, a commotion breaks out when a vegetarian student discovers meat in the lentils. The students bring out six kitchen workers, who fall to their knees and ask for mercy. Avinash intervenes, saying that the caterer is to blame, not his workers. He convinces them to lodge a protest with the college instead of hurting the workers.

Avinash proves that he is generous with how he helps Maneck, and also intelligent, as his win in the chess tournament demonstrates. Like Rustom, he proves that sometimes people with the best qualities don't come from money or high status. Avinash further proves his kindness and intelligence by standing up for the workers and instead blaming their boss. His decision to advocate for a protest instead of violence recalls the long history of nonviolent protest in India, notably from Mahatma Gandhi.



The caterer loses his job, and Maneck, Avinash, and the other students celebrate. Avinash starts organizing around other causes, like getting cockroaches and bedbugs out of the rooms. Maneck is interested at first, but he and Avinash slowly grow apart as Avinash gets deeper into organizing.

Even after his victory against the caterer, Avinash doesn't celebrate and instead continues his campus organizing. In many ways, Avinash's constant desire to help others resembles Dr. Shroff, perhaps foreshadowing that Avinash won't be able to keep things up forever.



Avinash tells Maneck he read in the newspaper that Prime Minister was accused of cheating in the last elections and was supposed to step down. People protested to demand her resignation, but instead she declared the Emergency in order to stay in power. Avinash has less and less time for chess, and eventually Maneck stops seeing him.

Avinash's complaints about the rigged elections raise the possibility that he'll soon be in danger, given how Narayan died complaining about the elections. Although Maneck does not necessarily support the changes that come with Emergency, his growing distance from Avinash reveals that Maneck is also not quite an idealist like his friend.



New student groups called Students for Democracy and Students Against Fascism show up on campus to silence those who oppose the Emergency. They shut down the newspaper and get the professors to sign patriotism pledges. Maneck hates this and worries for Avinash but tries to avoid trouble.

The groups that claim to support democracy and oppose fascism instead try to control the campus press and the professors, which is very undemocratic. Once again, this shows how the government's policies increasingly come to have an effect on the daily life of ordinary people.



One day, Maneck is walking to the toilet and gets apprehended by some older students as part of "ragging" (hazing). Because he's studying refrigeration and air conditioning, they lock him in a freezer for 10 minutes. They then force him to masturbate to prove that his "thermostat" is working. After this, Maneck writes home to Farokh and Aban that he wants to leave the hostel and would promise to do exactly as Farokh wants in the family shop.

"Ragging," a controversial real-life practice, shows here how cutthroat things are at Maneck's school, with older students looking for opportunities to humiliate students who are more vulnerable than them. The novel seems to draw a connection between the cruelty that is encouraged (or at least permitted) at schools and the selfishness or cruelty that some adults display later in life.



Farokh would like Maneck to come home but feels he has to make some attempt to let him stay at college. This is when Zenobia comes to Aban with her idea about Maneck staying with Dina. Now, in the present, Maneck gets embarrassed about having to bathe around Dina, even though she is much older.

Although Maneck and Dina come from different situations, they share a common status as outcasts who end up living together because they don't fit into where they would traditionally belong (with Nusswan or a new husband for Dina and at his college hostel for Maneck).



CHAPTER 6

On the day that Maneck arrives at Dina's, Ishvar and Omprakash plan to get to Dina's early because they see red double-decker buses arriving outside the slum and don't like the look of them. But when Omprakash hears that the bus drivers are promising to pay people and give them a snack in order to ride the buses to a meeting with Prime Minister, he is tempted to go. Rajaram says everything the bus drivers say is a lie. When the bus isn't full enough, a police officer, Sergeant Kesar, starts forcing people to come or otherwise get arrested for trespassing.

Once again, the novel explores how instead of being neutral enforcers of the law, the police can play a role in supporting the status quo and the government, even when that comes at the expense of people in the lower classes. Prime Minister's orders to bus the slum residents to a speech shows no regard for the slum residents themselves and how they might have to work jobs during the day to get paid. Once again, the government treats poor people as expendable, even as Prime Minister seems to need them in the audience for her speech.



Ishvar, Omprakash, and Rajaram end up on the bus, although Ishvar worries the whole time about what Dina will think about them missing work. The bus drives about an hour outside the city. The bus stops near a lot of other buses, and everyone gets packed in together for a rally. One of the other people on the bus is Monkey-man, a street performer from the slum who has two monkeys and a dog in his act.

Prime Minister appears onstage in a white sari with some other officials. When Prime Minister speaks, there's lots of applause from right near the stage, and this makes the rest of the audience cheer too. In her speech, she explains the necessity of the Emergency but also why people shouldn't be afraid.

Omprakash and Rajaram play cards during the speech until an audience monitor scolds them to be more respectful. After many more speeches, everyone finally gets paid as they board the bus back. The total is one rupee less than promised, in order to pay for bus fare and for the snack (which they never received). Monkey-man finds that his dog, which always used to get along well with his monkeys, has now killed both of them because it got too hungry. Monkey-man nearly kills the dog.

Meanwhile, Dina gets angry with Maneck when he returns from college later than promised. She tells him how Ishvar and Omprakash didn't show up that day. At dinner, Dina asks Maneck if he eats with his hands or with cutlery. When he says he uses cutlery, she sets out a knife and fork for him but doesn't for herself. Halfway through the meal, however, she changes her mind and tries a knife and fork. After dinner, Dina shows Maneck her cloth collection—she's collecting different scraps with the goal of ultimately making a **quilt**.

The next evening, when Maneck again returns late from college, Dina asks Maneck to never mention to Ishvar and Omprakash how mad she was about them missing the previous day. She scolds Omprakash and Ishvar not to let Prime Minister take them away again, but secretly, she is desperate to keep her two employees. Later, Dina gets angry at Maneck when she smells smoke on him, but he says truthfully that he was just sitting and talking with Ishvar and Omprakash. Dina gets annoyed that Omprakash and Maneck start going off on their own for breaks.

The crowded, impersonal nature of the bussing emphasizes how, in the government's view, Ishvar, Omprakash, and Rajaram are just props to appear at the speech and that their actual identities are not important. In a way, they all become like the monkeys and dog who perform for Monkey-man, as Prime Minister forces them to put on a show.



A sari is a traditionally Indian garment, and so this passage shows how, like many politicians, Prime Minister tries to signal her patriotism even through small details like her choice of clothing.



Even on issues as small as one rupee and a snack, the government fails to keep its promises to poor people like Omprakash, Ishvar, and Rajaram. These broken promises contrast sharply with the optimistic tone of Prime Minister's speech. Even more alarming is the death of Monkey-man's monkeys. It shows the dangers of hunger and how it can make previously docile animals like the dog turn violent—a grim foreshadowing of how things might also turn out for some of the humans.



At first Dina tries to eat with her hands because it's what she's used to, but when she switches to cutlery, she seems to once again be trying to impress Maneck and hide her money problems. The quilt that Dina shows here goes on to become an important symbol in the novel. The way that the quilt combines different scraps to create a unified whole represents how Dina has built a new life for herself by pulling together scraps, as well as standing for the patchwork nature of India as a whole.



This passage explores the complicated dynamic that Dina must navigate with Maneck, Ishvar, and Omprakash. On the one hand, she wants to project authority and get them to respect her. At the same time, however, she fears that if she's too harsh, she'll drive them away—and she needs them to stay more than she lets on. The smoke that gets on Maneck from Ishvar and Omprakash reflects how the two of them are beginning to influence him.



When Maneck and Omprakash are alone, they often talk about girls. They consider seeing an action movie called *Revolver Rani* but don't have the money. Omprakash tells Maneck about Shanti from his slum. Eventually, the two of them save some money and go to see the movie. Afterwards, they quote lines from the movie to each other.

The action movie Revolver Rani seems to be an outlet for the frustrations that Maneck and Omprakash each have in their own lives. Omprakash, for example, wants revenge because of what happened to his family, but because he can't challenge Thakur Dharamsi on his own, he instead seeks fictional catharsis in a movie.



Dina thinks that Omprakash is getting distracted from his work, and he starts making mistakes with the dresses. She comes to rely on Ishvar, who is more dependable. Dina starts to rely on Maneck to oversee Ishvar and Omprakash at work, and she stops padlocking them in. One day while Dina is gone, Omprakash and Maneck hold Dina's sanitary pads to their crotches and start jousting with them, and Dina walks in on them. Dina shows Ishvar, who is hard at work sewing, what Omprakash and Maneck are doing to shame them.

Dina's decision to stop padlocking Ishvar and Omprakash into her home shows that she is beginning to trust them more as time goes on. This decision comes with consequences, however, as Omprakash and Maneck begin to test the limits of what they can get away with while living with Dina. The fake crotch jousting that Maneck and Omprakash engage in shows once again how the violent side of masculinity fascinates them.



Dinner that evening is awkward. The next day, Maneck apologizes to Dina. She says she's mad because, while she expects that behavior from Omprakash, she expects better from Maneck because he's from a nice family.

Although Dina has begun to trust Omprakash and Ishvar more, her comment about expecting more from Maneck suggests that she still holds some prejudices about people from lower classes (or perhaps she feels that she needs to pretend to feel prejudice, for Maneck's sake).



CHAPTER 7

Ishvar and Omprakash invite Maneck to dinner at their house, and Dina is surprised and disappointed when Maneck accepts—she wants Maneck to distance himself from her employees. Ishvar and Omprakash leave one evening to have dinner in their slum, the evening before Maneck is set to come, but when they arrive, they're surprised to see no smoke from anyone else's cooking fires. All of a sudden, there is a sound in the distance of people in pain and terror.

Dina's feeling that she and Maneck should separate themselves from Ishvar and Omprakash seems to suggest once again that, in spite of Dina's own status as an outsider with money problems, she still has prejudices against people from lower classes. Maneck, on the other hand, seems more open to getting to know Ishvar and Omprakash, perhaps because as a man and as someone from an even wealthier family, he feels more secure about his own status.



Rajaram tells Omprakash and Ishvar that men from the government came in and destroyed all the huts in the neighborhood with big machines. Apparently, this is legal due to the Emergency.

The government destroys the huts without providing any alternative form of shelter for the slum's residents, showing once again how the government treats them as expendable.



Omprakash and Ishvar scavenge some of their possessions from the wreckage. Rajaram tries to save part of his stock of hair. Ishvar decides they should go see Nawaz, but when they arrive at his house, strangers are living there. Apparently, he has been arrested for smuggling gold, although the stranger claims this was just a pretext, and in fact, Nawaz was arrested for quarreling with a well-connected man.

Nawaz's name and his connection with Ashraf could suggest that he is Muslim, showing how a religious divide remains in some parts of India in spite of the end of the earlier riots. The fact that Nawaz got arrested for quarreling with a well-connected man suggests how in Prime Minister's India, social connections (or lack thereof) carry even more weight than the law.



With nowhere else to go, Omprakash and Ishvar decide to sleep at the railway station, but it's already full of beggars. A policeman stops them and tells them they can't stay. He implies that the other beggars there have all paid him a bribe to be allowed to stay. Ishvar and Omprakash tell him they don't plan to stay, then wait for him to leave before going to sleep. But right after they fall asleep, a policeman pours cold water on them to wake them up.

The policeman acts cruelly toward Omprakash and Ishvar, pouring water on them instead of letting them sleep, all because he sees the opportunity to make some more money for himself in the form of bribes. The scene has a dark humor to it, as Ishvar and Omprakash used to struggle to get enough water in the slum but now find themselves with too much of it.



Omprakash and Ishvar arrive at Dina's early for once, with a trunk full of their things that they hope to leave with her, without revealing that they're now homeless. They tell Maneck they'll have to postpone dinner. When they go back to where their hut used to be, Sergeant Kesar says they'll go to jail if they try to build in that area again due to new "city beautification" laws. Ishvar wonders whether they should let Dina know about their problems, although Omprakash is skeptical that she'd help.

One of the recurring themes in this novel is how the government frequently uses harmless-sounding euphemisms to describe darker policies. While "city beautification" sounds like a worthwhile goal, the real purpose of the laws seems to be to force people like Ishvar and Omprakash to leave by destroying their homes. Once again, this passage highlights the unusual priorities of law enforcement officers—Sergeant Kesar will arrest poor people for trying to build a home in the wrong area, but no one will investigate the murder of Ishvar and Omprakash's other family members.



Ishvar tells Dina and Maneck everything about how their home was destroyed. Ishvar asks if he and Omprakash can sleep on Dina's verandah, but she's afraid of the rent collector seeing them. She also makes them take back their trunk, which Maneck later scolds her for. In their search for a place to sleep, Ishvar and Omprakash find a nightwatchman and reach a deal where they'll pay him to sleep on a mat near him.

After initially beginning to trust Ishvar and Omprakash more, Dina now seems to be afraid of going further and instead tries to reassert her difference from her two employees. The nightwatchman, who is never named in the story, represents how even in the seemingly indifferent environment of the city, there are people who are willing to show kindness to strangers.



Ishvar and Omprakash spend a couple nights with the nightwatchman. One day at Dina's, they get a surprise visit from Rajaram, who has found a new job. They make plans to meet at the nightwatchman's place, where Dina won't be listening. When they talk later, they learn that Rajaram now has a job as a "Motivator" distributing leaflets to promote birth control. Rajaram says there are plenty more openings for Motivators, but Ishvar and Omprakash turn him down. Dina changes her mind and allows Ishvar and Omprakash to keep their trunk with her, wondering about its contents.

Dina's concession to allow Ishvar and Omprakash to leave their trunk with her shows how she is slowly beginning to accept their presence in her life. Rajaram's new work as a "Motivator" seems to signify yet another shift in Indian culture, as Rajaram shifts from the international hair-selling business to a job that promotes a government program, reflecting how the Emergency caused many in the country to look inward instead of thinking internationally.



CHAPTER 8

Ishvar and Omprakash get used to the noise by the nightwatchman's post and learn to sleep well. One night, they hear noises and see that Sergeant Kesar is clearing out all the beggars in a different part of the city. With him is a man that they recognize as the Facilitator. Ishvar and Omprakash stay hidden and listen to Sergeant Kesar and the Facilitator talk. The Facilitator is trying to recruit laborers from the people Sergeant Kesar kicks out. To meet his quota, the Facilitator needs two more.

Sergeant Kesar finds Ishvar and Omprakash. The nightwatchman tries to defend them, but Sergeant Kesar insists on taking them. Ishvar tells Sergeant Kesar that they know the Facilitator, but nothing will stop the sergeant, and he hits Omprakash with his stick.

Ishvar and Omprakash end up in a truck next to a beggar with no legs or hands that they talk to for a while. He tells them about a man called Beggarmaster who disfigures people or gives them illnesses so that they can earn more sympathy—and more money—as beggars.

The truck drives all night and stops in the morning at a small village on a dirt road. The Facilitator lets the truck passengers relieve themselves and makes tea for them. The truck keeps going to an irrigation project. A foreman leads them to tin huts, and everyone rushes to claim one. The foreman explains that the workers will get food, shelter, and clothing but no salary. Ishvar is sure that it's a mistake and he and Omprakash will be able to get out.

Meanwhile, Dina and Maneck wonder why Ishvar and Omprakash haven't shown up for work. Eventually the nightwatchman runs into Maneck and relays how Ishvar and Omprakash were taken away. Dina refuses to do anything, so Maneck goes off to his room to get away from her. He thinks of his past with Farokh and Aban, and he tries to imagine what Dina's life was like with Rustom. He begins to cry.

The coordination between The Facilitator and Sergeant Kesar shows once again how the law favors people with business interests while disregarding those from the lower ranks of society. The prevalence of quotas in the novel continues to show how industrialization and a desire for efficiency have begun to influence modern Indian culture.



This scene once again shows the indifference of the law to Ishvar and Omprakash's plight. They get taken away despite having done nothing wrong, and the Sergeant's hitting of Omprakash shows how he is willing to abuse his power.



Beggarmaster seems at first to be a figure of extreme cruelty, with how he hurts people just to make them more effective beggars. As the story progresses, however, the question becomes to what extent Beggarmaster is just a pragmatic figure trying to succeed in an environment that often values cruelty.



Ishvar's faith that things will turn out well at the work camp, even after everything he's seen so far in the city, could seem naïve, but it could also suggest his understanding that hope is an important resource for surviving difficult times. His ability to stay hopeful even after so many setbacks demonstrates the resilience of his character.



Dina's refusal to take any risk herself for the sake of helping Ishvar and Omprakash is in some ways similar to Nawaz (who went to jail anyway, in spite of his caution). But Dina has shown that she can evolve over the course of the novel, and her feelings toward Ishvar and Omprakash have already come a long way from where they started.



Maneck goes back to Dina and says he'll help her sew. She's reluctant at first but agrees to teach him. They work hard for a while, then take a break. Their conversation turns philosophical, and Maneck gives his theory that God is like a giant **quilt**-maker who has abandoned his creation because the pattern became too complex.

Dina's willingness to accept help from Maneck shows how she has begun to let go of some of her pride and get resourceful about trying to make a living. Maneck's metaphor of God as a quilt-maker is fitting because of the quilt that Dina is making. But while Dina's quilt represents unity, Maneck's philosophy is a bit darker, suggesting that the "quilt" of creation might just be chaos, with no discernable patterns.



Dina tries to end for the day, but Maneck wants to keep going. He claims that his college lectures have been canceled for the next two days. She doesn't believe him but agrees to do a couple more dresses.

Maneck's willingness to help Dina indicates his growing affection toward her, perhaps partly romantic (given his uneasiness earlier about bathing around her).



Meanwhile, Ishvar tells the foreman that there's been a mistake. The foreman reassures him that there hasn't been. Ishvar struggles with the work of moving gravel in baskets for the irrigation. Omprakash gets distracted watching women as they bend over to pick up baskets. Ishvar claims to be sick and tries to see the manager, but the foreman rejects him. Ishvar and Omprakash meet up again with the legless beggar they sat next to in the truck. He offers them extra food, because he has a friend in the kitchen, and says his name is Shankar.

Once again, Ishvar and Omprakash find that the most helpful and least selfish people are often the ones who have the least to give. Shankar is a beggar who doesn't even have legs, and yet he offers additional food to Ishvar and Omprakash, unlike the foreman who refused to help them at all. The conditions that Omprakash and Ishvar are in—performing unpaid labor that they can't escape—resemble slavery, showing how bad civil liberties have gotten during the Emergency.



CHAPTER 9

Dina delivers the dresses she made with Maneck and then tells Mrs. Gupta that Ishvar and Omprakash are away on a two-week vacation. But she has to extend it, and Mrs. Gupta gives her another two weeks, but says she won't accept any more delays. Mrs. Gupta hopes the Emergency will help everything run in an orderly fashion again.

Mrs. Gupta's continued faith in the Emergency contrasts sharply with the dire conditions that Omprakash and Ishvar find themselves in at the irrigation work camp. This passage highlights how wealthier people like Mrs. Gupta were spared from the Emergency's worst effects and perhaps even benefited.



When Dina gets back home, Ibrahim is there to collect rent, and she pays him. He drops some papers and says he needs to sit down, as an excuse to come into her home and inspect whether there's an illegal business there. Once inside, he asks if he can fix anything in her house. Dina knows he just wants to look around. She allows him to see the room with the two sewing machines but says there's nothing illegal about owning two machines.

Ibrahim's behavior in this passage shows the extreme lengths that he is willing to go to, all for the sake of pleasing his boss, the landlord. Dina and Ibrahim's conversation shows how convoluted renting laws are in the city as well as how, when a powerful person like a landlord wants to come up with an excuse to evict someone, it is often easy to find one.



When Ibrahim references a young man renting a room in Dina's house, she insults Ibrahim for spreading false rumors about a poor widow. He leaves, and later, Maneck enjoys hearing Dina's retelling of events. Two weeks pass, and Dina realizes that she actually looks back fondly on when Ishvar and Omprakash worked for her. She fears she'll have to borrow money from Nusswan for rent.

The absence of Ishvar and Omprakash forces Dina to realize how much she enjoys the company of others, despite her earlier complaints about her two employees. Dina has begun to realize that escaping from Nusswan's household has allowed her to begin building her own nontraditional family unit.



The Facilitator comes back to the work camp with more new workers, and the foreman greets him. Some of the paid workers on the irrigation project get laid off now that there are new free laborers to replace them. As things get more crowded, food becomes scarce, and Ishvar and Omprakash start to feel faint during the workday. The camp also runs out of shoes, so they have to walk barefoot.

The dire conditions on the camp show once again how the government is restricting people's liberties. In addition to living under difficult conditions themselves, the free laborers make life more difficult for the paid workers by making them seem too costly by comparison.



One day, Ishvar gets dizzy, falls, and hurts his foot. His ankle swells, so an overseer tells him to focus on filling baskets rather than carrying them so that he can work sitting down. Others in the camp get even worse injuries. The foreman tries to blame the Facilitator for giving him bad workers, but the Facilitator just drops off the next batch of people, saying the police often force everyone into the truck.

Ishvar's foot injury is similar to the injury that his own father, Dukhi, received from the mortar of a Thakur. Yet again, the foot injury signifies a lack of mobility, connecting to how Ishvar and Omprakash have no way to escape the irrigation work camp.



Many of the new arrivals are street performers, so the foreman gives them the option to work as camp entertainers. Monkey-man is among them, and he does an act with two small children, his niece and nephew. He balances them on a pole and holds them way up high, but everyone gets angry and calls the act cruel. He tries to defend himself, but people don't listen.

This passage, which directly revolves around a feat of balance, seems to have contributed in part to the novel's title. Monkey-man tries to involve his niece and nephew in an act because performing is all he knows how to do, but the crowd gets angry with him. The fact that the crowd attacks him (instead of considering the social forces that might have led Monkey-man to perform such a desperate act) is a darker version of when Avinash successfully stops a crowd from attacking the dining hall workers who are victims of larger forces.



Beggarmaster comes to the camp and recognizes his old worker Shankar (whom he calls Worm). Shankar has no legs but gets around in a wheeled device he calls a gaadi (the word for "car" or "vehicle"). Beggarmaster offers to pay the Facilitator 2,000 rupees for everyone in the camp, including Shankar. The Facilitator is very happy with this price and agrees, then cuts the foreman in on a share.

This passage once again suggests that corruption and profit motive played a large role during the Emergency. Although Beggarmaster is just looking to make money for himself, his actions end up helping Shankar and potentially offering a way out of the camp for Ishvar and Omprakash too.



Shankar tells Ishvar and Omprakash that he's going back with Beggarmaster. He says he can get Beggarmaster to take them too, but Beggarmaster is less interested when he hears that the two of them want to be tailors, not beggars. Eventually, Beggarmaster offers to support them for 50 rupees a week, which is very expensive for Ishvar and Omprakash, but they feel they have no choice but to accept. Beggarmaster warns them that if they try to leave him without paying, he'll find them.

Omprakash felt like he was rich earlier when he received 50 rupees for getting hit by a car, and this helps place into context how difficult it will be for the two of them to come up with 50 rupees each week. In spite of this, the corrupt offer that Beggarmaster gives them is still worse than if they stuck with the government irrigation program, where they would never have any chance of making money at all.



Monkey-man was knocked out when the crowd turned against him earlier. Beggarmaster doesn't take him, but he does take Monkey-man's little niece and nephew in the truck, which the Facilitator has let him borrow.

The casual way that Beggarmaster takes Monkey-man's niece and nephew without even consulting him shows that, while Beggarmaster is capable of kindness, he can also be ruthless and uncaring at times.



Dina dresses up to go visit Nusswan at his office, and Maneck thinks she looks very beautiful. He comes with her to Nusswan's office building. Nusswan wants Dina to become a bigger part of his family again and get more involved in the lives of Xerxes and Zarir. Dina goes to Nusswan's office and introduces Maneck. They make small talk, until eventually Nusswan goes off on a conspiracy theory about how the CIA is trying to sabotage India's Family Planning Programme (that Rajaram works for).

At first Nusswan seems welcoming, offering Dina a chance to become a bigger part of his family once again. But as the conversation goes on, Nusswan begins to reveal more of his true colors, showing his support for controversial government policies like the Family Planning Programme (which included forced sterilizations).



Dina learns that Nusswan is a big defender of Prime Minister's policies and thinks that death is what many people in the slums deserve. Dina jokes that Nusswan should at least be careful not to kill her two tailors, but he accuses her of not being able to have a serious conversation. At last Dina comes around to her request: 250 rupees. Nusswan gives her the money, and she can't make eye contact with him. As they leave, Dina tells Maneck about how Nusswan used to brag as a boy about wanting to hunt big game animals but was afraid of killing even a mouse in real life.

When Nusswan says that many people in the slums deserve death, he makes explicit something that seems to be the hidden motivation behind recent laws that make life difficult for slum residents. As much as Dina disagrees with her brother's politics, she feels shame over the fact that she still needs his money regardless. Nusswan's own fear of killing even a mouse reflects how he lives a life very distant from the slums and doesn't have to witness the death and suffering in them.



CHAPTER 10

Beggarmaster drives the truck to a shanty town, and Ishvar and Omprakash learn that some slums were able to avoid destruction if the slumlord had a good relationship with the police. Beggarmaster goes with Ishvar and Omprakash to verify their job. Ishvar worries about going to see Dina so late at night but agrees. Dina is initially afraid of the doorbell, but she's relieved when she realizes who it is. Dina confirms that the men work for her.

The fact that some slums managed to avoid destruction if their slumlords had the right connections shows once again the role that corruption plays in the city. By allying themselves with Beggarmaster, Ishvar and Omprakash have tried to turn this corruption to their advantage, in part because they have few other options available to them.



Ishvar and Omprakash explain everything to Dina. Dina is desperate to keep her tailors but wonders how strict she should be with them about their absence. They sleep on her verandah that night, then make plans to go to the Vishram Vegetarian Hotel the next morning (where Shankar is begging) before they start sewing. Maneck reluctantly leaves them for the day to go to his college.

After seeing Shankar and getting some food, Omprakash and Ishvar go back to Dina's to start work. Throughout the workday, Dina debates whether she should offer for Ishvar and Omprakash to sleep on her verandah, at least until they find a new place. Ultimately, she makes the offer, and they gratefully accept. She refuses rent, claiming to Maneck that it's so Ibrahim can't count them as tenants.

Dina gets used to a new household routine with more people living with her. One day, Rajaram shows up again at Dina's to see Ishvar and Omprakash. He sounds desperate, so they make plans to meet later at the Vishram Vegetarian Hotel. There, they learn he's been let go from his family planning job. His supervisors found him a poor Motivator. He lost his job, as well as his shelter, food source, and bicycle. Now, he wants to get back into hair collecting and barbering somehow.

Ishvar goes to Dina and gets an old haircutting kit that he can give to Rajaram. Rajaram asks if he can store some of his hair collection with Ishvar, since he has nowhere else to put it. Ishvar doesn't think all the hair will fit in his trunk, but he reluctantly agrees.

Dina decides to start making food for Ishvar and Omprakash, and Maneck convinces her to let them eat at the table instead of on the verandah. At their first dinner Maneck proposes that everyone should pool their money together for meals in order to save, with Ishvar and Omprakash focusing on their specialty of making chapatis (flatbreads).

Cats start coming to the window of Dina's house. Omprakash gives the cats some extra chapatis, but Dina tells him to close the window, wondering if she's become too lenient. Still, over time Dina gets used to her new guests.

By allowing Ishvar and Omprakash to sleep on her verandah, Dina takes the first step toward inviting them into her home. She seems to finally admit how much she needs the two of them and how much she enjoys their company. Maneck's reluctance to leave shows how he himself is beginning to view Dina's house more like a home.



Dina tries to tell Ishvar and Omprakash that she's only refusing rent to keep Ibrahim away, but it's becoming increasingly clear to everyone that she wants to help Ishvar and Omprakash. Dina overcomes her fear of not living up to her social class and doesn't let it stop her from building a deeper connection with Omprakash and Ishvar.



Rajaram's sudden unemployment illustrates the fickleness of the government and how it shows little loyalty to workers like him. Although the job seemed at first to offer Rajaram progress, he ends up right back where he was at the start of the novel, reflecting yet another example of a government promise that ends up being empty.



Although Ishvar doesn't have much to give, he offers Rajaram a place to store his hair collection, reciprocating for earlier in the novel when Rajaram offered what little he had (like his stove) to Ishvar and Omprakash.



The food that Dina makes for Ishvar, Omprakash, and Maneck continues to show how she is beginning to view them as family. Maneck takes the idea a step further, getting each member of the household to contribute in the way that they know best.



The cats that come to the windowsill further demonstrate how Dina is beginning to open her home up. As was the case earlier, Dina sometimes feels regret about opening herself up at first but learns to adapt to her new situation before long.



One day, Ishvar proposes cooking a recipe he learned from Rajaram. Everyone works together to cook it, and when they're done, Maneck praises it more than anything Dina has ever cooked alone, which Dina pretends to be upset about. Dinners become more complex, and Maneck teaches Omprakash how to use a knife and fork.

The meal represents the combined efforts of everyone living in Dina's home. When they all come together, they manage to cook something even better than what Dina can cook alone, showing the value of teamwork.



Dina starts working on her **quilt** again. Ishvar goes to Dina and asks for advice about making a garment for the legless Shankar. Rajaram has suddenly had some good fortune and started depositing a lot of hair into the trunk at Dina's place.

Dina's renewed interest in her quilt seems to be a sign of how her house, like the quilt, has become a place for people who are the "scraps" of society (like the scraps of fabric in her quilt) to come together like a family.



CHAPTER 11

Mrs. Gupta uses "goondas" (hired gangsters) to prevent a strike at her factory. Dina is in no hurry for Ishvar and Omprakash to leave, but Ishvar insists that they must find their own place so that Omprakash can get married. Maneck tells Omprakash that, instead of getting a one-year college degree, he is considering staying on for three more years for a full degree course.

The goondas that Mrs. Gupta hires shows how her comfortable lifestyle is only possible due in part to violence. Maneck's decision to try to go to college for another three years, despite his earlier bad experiences at school, suggests how important this new community at Dina's house has become for him.



One day Ibrahim comes by unexpectedly, and Ishvar and Omprakash immediately silence their sewing machines. Ibrahim tells Dina she's evicted because they have proof she's running a business. He goes and finds Ishvar and Omprakash at the sewing machines. Dina says that Ishvar is her husband and Omprakash is her son, and if Ibrahim doesn't stop harassing her, she'll take him to court. Eventually, Ibrahim leaves.

Just as everyone at Dina's house seems to be forming a new family, the eviction notice from Ibrahim threatens to break this new unit apart. Dina, however, shows her commitment to keeping this new family together, lying that Ishvar is her husband and Omprakash is her son—although in some ways, this lie contains a kernel of truth.



Maneck comes back to Dina's place from college for three weeks during Divali. A monsoon keeps everyone inside, and Maneck starts teaching Omprakash how to play chess. Omprakash doesn't like the concept of a stalemate—he believes the game should always have a winner.

Divali (also spelled Diwali) is a Hindu festival of light. Omprakash's frustration with chess and the possibility for the game to end without a winner seems to reflect his general frustration with his situation in life, where it sometimes seems impossible to win. The lack of a winner could also reflect how in situations like the Emergency, conflict doesn't always lead to a winner, with everyone suffering.



Omprakash and Maneck stop by the shop of a local tailor named Jeevan. They want to measure customers, but Jeevan guesses correctly that they just want to touch ladies' bosoms. They ask instead if they can secretly watch women undress. Although reluctant at first, Jeevan eventually lets them watch for a fee. While watching a woman, Omprakash makes a noise, and Jeevan has to quickly reassure her that it's just rats. After that, Jeevan kicks them out.

While Omprakash spends most of his time with Ishvar, who discourages his impulsive behavior, Omprakash finds an ally in Maneck. Jeevan's willingness to go along with their plan, for a cost, is yet another example in the story of how men often fail to consider the feelings of women.



Omprakash gets an idea about how to look through the bathroom door while Dina is bathing. Maneck is reluctant to go along with it. Omprakash persists until Maneck slaps him and tells him to stop. After this Dina is sad to see that there is tension at the dinner table.

As is often the case, Omprakash wants to keep pushing the boundaries of what's acceptable. But for Maneck, spying on Dina is different from spying on someone he doesn't know, perhaps reflecting his knowledge that what he did earlier is wrong.



Ibrahim comes back and gives Dina an oral notice that she has only 48 hours to vacate her home where she's running an illegal business. Dina tells Ishvar to go to the police, but one of the goondas with Ibrahim stops him. The goondas go in and destroy all of the dresses that are in the house. Maneck starts hitting a goonda with an umbrella, so one of the goondas punches him in the face. A goonda draws a knife, but Ibrahim warns everyone not to fight. Against Ibrahim's orders, some of the goondas shatter a window.

The presence of the goondas shows how, with the police busy doing the work of the government, brute force and corruption become a powerful tool for people like Dina's landlord. As Ibrahim watches the goondas destroy Dina's house, he witnesses the consequences of his own actions. Although at first Ibrahim is just watching out for the landlord by protecting the house, this passage marks a transition point in his character, particularly his feelings about his job.



Dina despairs that she's finished. Ishvar begins to insult Ibrahim, and Dina joins in. To their surprise, Ibrahim starts crying and says he hates his job. He doesn't like the damage that the goondas do to the property. Omprakash tells Maneck that he fought just like the actor Amitabh Bachchan, so he calls him "Umbrella Bachchan." Ishvar suggests that he and Omprakash could go back to the nightwatchman to make things easier on Dina, but she says instead she will just have to ask Nusswan for help.

Amitabh Bachchan was (and still is) one of the most famous actors in India, and many of his early roles were in action films. Ibrahim's crying about hating his job is an abrupt reversal, but it seems to have been building for a while, raising the question of how many people in the city who work in jobs that oppress others actually believe in the cause versus how many are stuck in their positions for economic reasons.



CHAPTER 12

Beggarmaster arrives at Dina's to collect Ishvar and Omprakash's money. She tells him that the next payment will be more difficult, but Beggarmaster insists on the money. He says that the goondas made a mistake by coming, but Beggarmaster will ensure that they don't come back. He asks for them to total up how much damage the goondas did, then says he'll get the landlord to settle.

While Beggarmaster makes a living on corruption, in many ways he has a greater sense of fairness than the government. Beggarmaster watches out for Dina in a way that renter protection laws should but often don't. Although Beggarmaster doesn't budge on his price, he also makes sure to get Dina money for the damage to her house.



Dina isn't sure whether or not to trust Beggarmaster, so she still plans to see Nusswan. Ishvar and Omprakash decide to go back to the nightwatchman, and Maneck reluctantly prepares to go back to the student hostel. But Ishvar and Omprakash find that there's a new nightwatchman who doesn't want to make a deal. They come back to Dina's and tell her they'll keep looking for a place to stay.

The replacement of the old nightwatchman with a new one reflects again how precarious life can be in the city for a poor person, with Ishvar and Omprakash's main source of shelter disappearing with no explanation. The new nightwatchman's refusal to make a deal only serves to highlight how generous the original nightwatchman was, at least by the standards of the city.



Just then, Beggarmaster comes back again. He says that two of his beggars have been killed. They had long, beautiful hair, but someone took it from their corpses. Ishvar and Omprakash are each shocked to hear this. Beggarmaster goes on to tell about how he's looking for two new beggars, one who's blind and one who can't walk but can ride on the shoulders of the blind one. He asks Ishvar and Omprakash to keep a lookout, then mentions that the goondas who harassed Dina just happened to break all their fingers in an accident.

The missing hair from the two beggars immediately points to Rajaram as a potential suspect. The death of these two beggars seems to mirror the death of Monkey-man's two monkeys, suggesting that like the hungry dog, Rajaram's circumstances have caused him to act unusually violent. Beggarmaster's vision of a new beggar duo could be a random musing or it could be a veiled threat of what might happen to Ishvar and Omprakash if they try to cross him. Once again, a lack of legs symbolizes how the poor lack social mobility.



After Beggarmaster leaves, Omprakash and Ishvar talk about how Rajaram must be the killer of the two beggars. Ishvar warns Omprakash never to bring the subject up again, to avoid them getting involved and having to deal with the police.

Even Ishvar, with his greater belief in traditional authority, doesn't want to trust official authorities like the police to handle this murder case, reflecting his growing skepticism toward these figures.



One night, Dina hears noises and fears the goondas are back. But it turns out to just be three kittens. Dina wants to just toss them outside, but eventually, everyone else convinces her not to. Maneck explains how to feed them. Omprakash suggests keeping the kittens in a box on the verandah, and Dina agrees but claims she's just waiting for the mother cat to come back. Ishvar considers the kittens a good omen and a sign that the mother cat trusted Dina.

The three kittens that show up at Dina's house could represent Maneck, Ishvar, and Omprakash, who are also three "strays" who show up at her house. Dina's reluctance to let the kittens stay is in line with her initial attitude toward her three guests, where she was also reluctant at first. The addition of the kittens further symbolizes how Dina has begun to open up her home and form a new community.



After three months, the kittens suddenly disappear, and no one knows what happened to them. Beggarmaster comes to collect his money and finds everyone in a gloomy mood because they miss the kittens. He tries to cheer them up by telling a story. He says he met an older beggar woman and, after talking to her, learned that she was Shankar's mother. She was called Nosey because she didn't have a nose.

The mysterious disappearance of the kittens is a potentially ominous sign, reflecting how quickly the new family that Dina has built could eventually fall apart. Beggarmaster's increasing sympathy toward Ishvar and Omprakash shows once again how he is a complicated character, in spite of the undeniably cruel things he has done in the past.



Beggarmaster's father bought Nosey, and not long after, she had a child—Shankar—who was soon taken away from her and "sent for professional modifications." As she was dying, Nosey told Beggarmaster that his father was also Shankar's father. This would make Shankar Beggarmaster's half-brother. Beggarmaster took Nosey to the hospital, but she died waiting for someone to treat her.

Beggarmaster gave the order to remove the legs and hands from Shankar, his own half-brother, to make him a better beggar. Although Beggarmaster seemed cold and motivated by money at first, learning about Shankar's true identity seems to shake Beggarmaster's belief in what he's doing.



Beggarmaster says he may tell Shankar the truth eventually, but first he wants Omprakash and Ishvar to talk to Shankar and find out how much he remembers of his past. Beggarmaster shows a drawing he made of some deformed-looking humans. He claims that all of humanity is “freaks.” Finally, Beggarmaster tells Omprakash and Ishvar that their contract will expire in four months, so they must decide about the next year immediately. Ishvar agrees to another year.

Beggarmaster’s belief that all of humanity is “freaks” seems in part to be a way of absolving himself from the guilt of how he transformed many of his beggars, including Shankar, into “freaks” with medical procedures. But it also shows how so many of the characters in the novel deal with feelings of isolation and not belonging with the people around them.



CHAPTER 13

The three kittens come back to Dina’s a month later. Ishvar continues to worry about getting Omprakash married, but Omprakash complains that no one is pressuring Maneck to marry, and he’s a similar age. Ishvar pushes forward anyway and says he’s written to Ashraf and found some families who would be willing to finalize a wedding within eight weeks. Dina doesn’t like this idea, and Ishvar gets surprisingly angry with her. Afterwards, Omprakash thanks Dina and promises to try to calm Ishvar down. Ishvar comes back to her and begs forgiveness.

In spite of his apology, Ishvar can’t let go of looking for a wife for Omprakash. Ishvar promises Dina that any wife of Omprakash’s will be a good influence on the house and not take up too much space. Dina resists at first but eventually tries to picture Omprakash’s future wife and agrees that she could also sleep on the verandah. They plan a trip where Omprakash will get married.

Over time, Omprakash begins to style himself more like Maneck. As an early wedding gift, Dina offers Omprakash a treatment to kill any potential parasites in his stomach. The next day, Omprakash goes to the toilet several times until a giant worm comes out of him. Dina explains that this is why he was always so thin.

One day, Rajaram unexpectedly shows up at Dina’s. Ishvar threatens to call the police. Rajaram asks for mercy and says he’s fallen on hard times. He asks Ishvar and Omprakash to come with him to get tea at the Vishram, where Dina and Maneck won’t overhear them.

As one of the only surviving members of his family, Ishvar seems to feel a responsibility to make sure the lineage continues, hence Omprakash’s marriage. Omprakash himself doesn’t seem to understand the weight his uncle puts on this issue, wishing instead for a life like Maneck’s (who faces his own family pressure and expectations, even though Omprakash doesn’t see it).



Dina’s willingness to let Omprakash bring a wife into the house further reinforces the idea that she now views Ishvar and Omprakash as family, with Omprakash being like a son. Ironically, when Ishvar himself was near Omprakash’s age, he also resisted marriage.



Just as the smoke on Maneck showed how Ishvar and Omprakash were influencing him, now Omprakash’s new styles show how Maneck is influencing him. The parasitic worm within Omprakash is a symbol for how society in general (like the irrigation work camp) has exploited people like him, leaving barely enough behind to survive.



Rajaram’s transformation from the friendly, knowledgeable slum resident to a haggard potential murderer reflects yet again how society’s indifference toward the poor has taken a toll on him.



Rajaram tells his problem—he went back to being a barber but couldn't resist the urge to chop off all of a client's hair. In his story, word spreads of what he does, and soon no one wants a haircut from him. Rajaram becomes hungry and homeless, looking enviously at people with long hair. He decides to try becoming a "pickhead," who steals people's hair. Rajaram admits that he was consumed by irrational desires and might have been better off just becoming a beggar.

People begin to talk about Rajaram's hair thefts, but mostly they just joke. Rajaram likes to find long-haired foreign hippies. Finally, Rajaram gets to the part of the story where he admits he killed the two beggars for their hair. Hearing this, Ishvar is horrified but reassures Rajaram that Beggarmaster doesn't know who the killer is. Rajaram says he only killed the two beggars because they woke in the middle of him trying to steal their hair and started to make a noise that would attract the police.

Rajaram says he believes people are still looking for him. Ishvar wonders if Rajaram should turn himself in. Instead, Rajaram wants to become a sanyasi (a type of ascetic) and meditate in a cave. Rajaram asks Ishvar for train fare to the Himalayas so that he can become a sanyasi. As Ishvar goes to get the money, Dina warns him that Rajaram might be scamming him. Ishvar goes ahead anyway and gives Rajaram some money before he leaves.

Rajaram's inability to stop himself from cutting off all of a person's hair shows how his need for money has made him desperate. At the same time, Rajaram recognizes that his obsession with hair is irrational and that it might be less efficient than other ways of earning money as a beggar. Like many characters, Rajaram builds a sense of identity based on how he earns a living, and he finds it difficult to let go of his old identity.



The progression from stealing hair from foreigners to murdering two beggars like himself shows how Rajaram's desperation has increased over time. Rajaram defends his actions by claiming self-preservation—he didn't want the police to catch him—providing yet another example in the story of how selfishness can lead to treating the lives of others as expendable.



Dina's concern that Rajaram is scamming Ishvar ends up being relevant later in the novel. Rajaram does indeed take a train to the Himalayas, but it ends up being the start of an even larger scam. Still, Ishvar's willingness to give Rajaram money, even knowing that he might waste it, shows how Ishvar is selfless in a way that stands out within the often-selfish atmosphere of the city. Ishvar remains grateful for the kindness Rajaram showed him long ago.



CHAPTER 14

Dina gets a big batch of dresses to Mrs. Gupta, then tells her there will be a six-week break (when Omprakash and Ishvar will be away for Omprakash's marriage). Not looking forward to being alone again, Dina works on her **quilt**. Ishvar and Omprakash, who haven't left yet, marvel at Dina's progress. Maneck suggests that Dina could just keep letting the quilt grow bigger and bigger, but she says this is foolish and that she's nearly at the size she wants.

Ishvar and Omprakash leave, and Maneck and Dina discuss how they hope Omprakash will be able to find a good wife. Maneck will also be leaving soon and taking final exams, but he promises he'll be back for his room before long. Maneck has conflicted feelings because he just got a letter from Farokh and Aban asking why he's staying at college three more years rather than coming home. Dina looks at the letter and says Maneck should follow his parents' advice to meet some of the Sodawalla family (Aban's relatives) nearby.

With Ishvar and Omprakash set to go away for a while and with Maneck also planning to leave soon, Dina faces the prospect of being alone again. As always, the patchwork quality of her quilt in part represents the patchwork new family she's built, and so by returning to work on her quilt, she seems to be trying to maintain this new community, even when her new guests will be gone.



Ishvar, Omprakash, Maneck, and Dina all make plans to turn their temporary living arrangement into something more permanent. The way the four of them have found community in Dina's house seems to present a hopeful message about how people from different parts of society can come together, standing in contrast to the divisions that keep people apart in other areas of the city.



Maneck leaves Dina's and happens to run into Shankar by the Vishram. Shankar says he's waiting for a haircut from Beggarmaster's barber. Maneck walks on. Shankar doesn't know that the Beggarmaster's usual barber declined the job but offered Rajaram as a replacement. Now, Rajaram arrives to give Shankar a haircut. Rajaram is nervous because he knows he should flee the city but he wants to earn a little more money first.

Rajaram starts by shaving Shankar and nicks him a little but without too much blood. But when Rajaram gets ready to cut Shankar's hair, Shankar protests that he wants to keep it long. He shows Rajaram two ponytails of hair that he's collected and says he wants Rajaram to permanently attach them to his own hair. Rajaram protests that this is impossible. Shankar continues to demand that Rajaram attach the hair, and he gets so loud that it draws a crowd.

Rajaram gets nervous about the crowd and slips away. People find Shankar with the two ponytails and accuse him of stealing the hair from somewhere. When a police officer arrives, Shankar tries to get away and everyone laughs. But his gaadi (wheeled device he moves in) gets too much momentum, and he flies into a busy intersection.

Maneck goes to try to find Avinash and return his chess set. Maneck arrives, and as expected, Avinash isn't around. But as Maneck looks for someone to leave the chess set with, he runs into an older couple who seem to be Avinash's parents. He says he's a friend of Avinash, and they say that they just cremated his body. He was missing for a long time and the body was only recently discovered in a morgue. Avinash was apparently found dead months earlier on the train tracks.

Maneck leaves feeling distraught, then remembers that he forgot to drop off the chess set. He decides to mail it back to Avinash's parents. He goes back to Dina's. Beggarmaster arrives, looking for Omprakash and Ishvar, forgetting they would be gone. Beggarmaster says he just learned recently that Shankar was killed in traffic, and his body is so twisted up in his gaadi that the two will have to be cremated together.

Rajaram's decision to stay in the city for one last haircut, while he's wanted for murder, shows how powerful the promise of making money can be. Unlike with the wealthy characters, Rajaram's motivation to keep seeking money seems to be more desperation than greed, and his difficult circumstances force him to make decisions that are dangerous for him.



Shankar's desire to put hair back on his head is irrational and recalls how Nusswan tried to reattach Dina's hair after she cut it short. The inability to put hair back on the head could be a metaphor for the inability to go back to the past, reflecting how there's no going back from modern India to how the country used to be.



People laugh at Shankar, even in the moments that lead to his death. Once again, the traffic in the city that kills Shankar (like it killed Rustom and injured Omprakash) suggests the effects of industrialization and how the increased pace of life in cities can also make it more dangerous for residents.



The death of Avinash is a sad but perhaps predictable outcome of the Emergency's crackdown on political organizing. The specific circumstances of Avinash's death, with his parents only learning about the body much later, shows the uncertainty that many lived with during the Emergency, and even after confirmation of Avinash's death, questions remain.



Avinash seemed to face an impossible situation in life, where either organizing or staying silent each came with consequences—similar to how chess itself can be a game with no winner. Meanwhile, Shankar's corpse forces Beggarmaster to see the consequences of his actions and how his decision to handicap Shankar so that he needed the gaadi ultimately led to his death.



Beggarmaster wants to invite Omprakash and Ishvar to attend Shankar's cremation. Maneck offers to go in their place, and Dina decides to go with him. Beggarmaster is pleased. At the cremation, Beggarmaster spares no expense. Dina is appalled that people at the cremation look apathetic and aren't mourning Shankar. At one point, some police begin to disrupt the event, mistaking it for a political gathering, but after Beggarmaster speaks to their commanding officer, the police instead agree to protect the procession.

Beggarmaster's elaborate arrangements at Shankar's funeral seem to be his way of dealing with the guilt and grief he feels about the way he treated Shankar while he was alive. Beggarmaster lives well outside the law, and so the fact that the police end up acting as his own personal guards for the procession shows how deeply corruption has become a part of daily life. Dina's observation that many people seem indifferent about Shankar's death suggests that perhaps it's not just the police who are acting for the sake of pleasing the powerful Beggarmaster.



Nusswan comes by and is surprised to see Dina with the funeral procession. He tries to get Dina to come with him for her safety but leaves her alone soon after Beggarmaster shows up.

Although Nusswan is influential in his own way due to his business, even he fears the influence of Beggarmaster. Unwilling to join the "legitimate" (but still sometimes morally compromised) world that Nusswan lives in, Dina has no choice but to depend on Beggarmaster.



Dina goes home and time passes slowly—she notices how quiet her house is without sewing machines. Maneck asks Dina if she's planning to sell the **quilt** she's working on, and Dina replies that it's actually going to be a gift for Omprakash's wedding—and that she'll make another for whenever Maneck's own wedding comes.

Even when she's alone, Dina can't help thinking about Maneck, Ishvar, and Omprakash. Becoming part of a larger community has helped to give Dina purpose, showing how in spite of the selfishness that is so prevalent in the city as a survival strategy, perhaps optimism can have even greater benefits.



Maneck finishes exams and goes to see the Aban's relatives, the Sodawallas. When he comes back, he complains to Dina that they all talk too much. When Maneck finally leaves the house, Dina looks forward to when Ishvar and Omprakash will be back in three weeks, then Maneck another three weeks later. In the meantime, she spends several days cleaning the house and tries again to imagine what Omprakash's wife will be like.

After the characters have all suffered and felt out of place, the end of this chapter seems to promise a hopeful future where Ishvar, Omprakash, Maneck and Dina find solidarity in a new family unit. Still, the departure of everyone from Dina's house leaves things in a state of uncertainty, particularly during the tumultuous times of the Emergency when Ishvar and Omprakash often disappear without explanation.



CHAPTER 15

Ishvar and Omprakash finally reunite with Ashraf Chacha in his village. Ashraf is happy to see them, but they can tell he's aged a lot since the last time they were back. They learn that Ashraf's wife died about six months after they left and that they apparently missed the letter about it that he sent. Aside from this and the opening of a new Family Planning Centre in town, most things have remained the same.

The death of Ashraf's wife and the changes in the village are yet another sign of the passage of time and how it isn't possible to go back. Still, the fact that Ashraf has remained himself in spite of his advancing age shows how people can remain resilient, even when faced with obstacles.



Ashraf offers Ishvar and Omprakash rice and dal, and Ishvar says that it feels like home to be back. They learn that Ashraf's money problems from the new clothing store in town only continued and that now Thakur Dharamsi is in charge of Family Planning. Omprakash wants to kill the Thakur for how he is still taking advantage of everyone in town, but Ashraf urges caution because the Thakur has government support.

Ashraf has managed to survive in spite of the fact that conditions for him have only gotten worse since Ishvar and Omprakash left town, again showing how he is resilient. The continued influence of Thakur Dharamsi, who still faces no consequences for his actions and even enjoys government support, again shows how corruption can lead to injustice.



The market is noisy because the Family Planning Centre is promoting a new sterilization camp that day where people can get quick vasectomies. Nearby, a man called the Potency Pedlar offers home solutions for various forms of impotence.

Sterilization camps were one of the most controversial aspects of the Emergency because some consider them a form of eugenics (attempting to "improve" a population's genes, often based on racist science). Once again, euphemisms like "Family Planning Centre" hide the potentially darker purpose behind these programs.



News that Omprakash is seeking a wife has spread throughout the local Chamaar community. The people in the community are glad Omprakash has returned, but Ishvar makes it clear that they plan to return back to the city, particularly since Thakur Dharamsi is still around.

Even after spending many years in the city, Ishvar and Omprakash retain standing in the Chamaar community, showing how people in the community still care for each other in spite of all the persecution that Chamaars have faced.



All of a sudden, while Ishvar, Omprakash, and Ashraf are in the market, several garbage trucks begin to surround the area, with police jumping out of them to grab people. Ashraf says something is wrong and they must escape, but Ishvar can't understand why they'd run like thieves if they've done nothing wrong. Before they can run, police try to get them into a truck. One hits Ashraf, and he goes down with a bleeding head. Ishvar wants to take care of him, but the police insist that Ishvar and Omprakash must go.

The trucks that surround the village square recall the earlier passages where the government bussed Ishvar and Omprakash out to see Prime Minister's speech or to work in the irrigation camp. The constant presence of buses and trucks to transport people once again shows how the poor have little freedom to choose where they go on their own (reflecting their lack of social mobility). It also shows how even the villages still face a similar level of government involvement as the cities, leaving people with nowhere to go to escape.



Ishvar and Omprakash get taken with several others in a truck toward a sterilization camp outside town. Men and women get separated into different tents. The district officials insist that even women who claim to be past child-bearing age should get the procedure. Eventually, there are so many people that equipment starts breaking down. Omprakash starts to cry when a woman near him is breastfeeding a child named Narayan.

Despite the assembly-line style of the sterilization camp, it soon becomes clear that the doctors there and their equipment can't handle all of the people coming in. The insistence of the district officials that even post-menopausal women should receive sterilization treatment shows how irrational the government policies are and how they treat people as a group rather than considering them as individuals.



The district officials tell the doctors to keep performing operations, regardless of how well their equipment is working, in order to meet Thakur Dharamsi's quotas. Ishvar pleads to the doctors that they can do the procedure on him, but they need to spare Omprakash, who has a wedding happening soon. But no one listens to his words.

Sterilization would prevent Omprakash from having children and effectively end his attempts to find a suitable marriage partner. Ishvar's insistence on helping Omprakash start a family seems to stem from his desire to see that their family line continues, whereas the sterilization camp seems to be yet another example of discrimination against Chamaars, limiting their future influence by stopping them from reproducing.



After the vasectomy procedure, Omprakash tries to stay dignified, but Ishvar despairs that Omprakash will never find a wife now. A man nearby tells them that vasectomies are reversible, although it can be very expensive. Ishvar is overjoyed and vows to sew like crazy for Dina to make lots of money for the operation.

The key to Ishvar's resilience is his sense of hope and his ability to imagine a potential positive outcome in spite of all the setbacks that he and Omprakash face. Although it would be nearly impossible for him and Omprakash to raise enough money to reverse a vasectomy, just the knowledge that it's possible helps Ishvar to endure their current situation.



All of a sudden, Thakur Dharamsi himself arrives at the camp. He stops by Omprakash's bed, and Omprakash tries not to show his face. Two nurses get Omprakash, and a doctor tells him that he has a tumor on his testicles, so Thakur Dharamsi has ordered for them to be removed. They chloroform Omprakash and remove his testicles. When Ishvar realizes what has happened, he is crushed.

Thakur Dharamsi's behavior shows his spiteful personality and how, even after killing all of Ishvar and Omprakash's other family members, he is not satisfied. The fact that the doctors all go along with Thakur Dharamsi's obviously false medical orders is yet another example of how people in the story allow terrible things to happen out of fear of losing their jobs.



Ashraf dies a few hours after being hit in the head in the market. Meanwhile, Omprakash continues to bleed a lot from his groin. He and Ishvar make it back to town to discover that Ashraf has died. Ishvar takes Omprakash to a local doctor who cleans the wound and says he should be OK if he doesn't walk for a week. Omprakash heals but will never be able to have children. Ishvar tries to lodge a complaint, but no one listens.

The death of Ashraf seems to represent the final death of all of Ishvar's good memories of living in the town as a boy. With no connection to his old home anymore, he and Omprakash are adrift to an even greater extent than before, with nothing left for them in the place they came from and also with no way back to the city where Dina lives.



A week later, Ishvar gets a fever, and his lower body turns black. He sees a doctor who offers pills for the fever, but the blackness keeps spreading. Ishvar has to have his legs amputated and spends two months in a hospital. Omprakash stays by his side but despite Ishvar's constant request for Omprakash to write a letter to Dina, he never does. Ishvar worries that he's become useless, but Omprakash says he's still better off than Shankar was.

Ishvar's fever seems to be a result of the rushed and unsanitary way that the doctors carried out the sterilization procedures. In a reversal of character roles, Omprakash becomes the one to console Ishvar with hopeful thoughts, pointing out that if someone like Shankar can find a way to survive in the city (at least for a while), Ishvar and Omprakash can also find ways to be resilient.



One day, Ashraf's nephew says he had to sell the shop because he got a good offer, and so Omprakash and Ishvar must leave. They agree to go back to Dina's, with Omprakash asking the nephew to construct a gaadi for Ishvar. About four months after coming to town, they get on a train to go back to the city.

The gaadi represents how Ishvar has been reduced to a state similar to Shankar's. He has gone from having an injured foot to losing his legs, showing how his mobility options continue to decrease as his financial situation worsens, as the government becomes more oppressive, and as he ages.



CHAPTER 16

Zenobia comes over to see the area Dina has set aside for Omprakash and his new bride. Later, Dina gets a letter from Maneck that he was refused admission to a degree program, so he can't continue with college. Now, instead, Farokh has arranged for Maneck to go work for one of his business contacts in Dubai. In the letter Maneck apologizes to Omprakash for not being able to meet his wife. When she's finished reading the letter, Dina cries.

Maneck's rejection from the college program seems to signal the end of the makeshift family unit that once lived in Dina's house. Farokh's decision to send Maneck to Dubai shows how opportunities for advancement have become limited for people within India during the Emergency, forcing some people who can afford it to seek new opportunities out of the country.



Dina goes to see Zenobia, who happens to be working on Mrs. Gupta's hair. Dina tells Zenobia about how Maneck isn't coming back, so she'll need a new guest. Zenobia promises to pass along anyone she hears of.

Dina tries to go back to Zenobia and find a new renter for her house who can help to give her life purpose, but just as hair can't go back onto the head, Dina can't recreate the circumstances of living with Maneck, Ishvar, and Omprakash.



Six weeks later, Omprakash and Ishvar still have not arrived as promised. Dina tells everyone asking for money, including Beggarmaster, that she's sure they just got held up with the wedding. Dina worries about the lack of payment from the tailors, but Beggarmaster says he'll protect her for the moment since she attended Shankar's cremation.

Beggarmaster's decision to forget about money and protect Dina because she showed up at Shankar's cremation represents a change for him as a character. Shankar's death seems to have forced Beggarmaster to examine his actions and reconsider the importance he has always put on money.



Dina gets another caller later that day who claims to be a friend of Ishvar and Omprakash. It turns out that man is Monkey-man. Monkey-man says he has some very important business to discuss with Beggarmaster. Dina says he just missed Beggarmaster, but Beggarmaster will be back next Thursday. Monkey-man thanks her and leaves.

Although Dina doesn't know it, Monkey-man has a strong reason to hold a grudge against Beggarmaster: Beggarmaster took Monkey-man's niece and nephew away from him while he was unconscious at the irrigation work camp. The violent deaths of Monkey-man's monkeys hints at the potential for more violence to come.



A week later, a man comes to reclaim the sewing machines from Dina because Ishvar and Omprakash haven't paid. Beggarmaster doesn't show up at his usual time. She gets a surprise when Ibrahim shows up instead, saying he's been dismissed by the landlord and shouldn't be seen at her house. Ibrahim thinks the landlord dismissed him because he was getting too soft. Dina says she's not afraid of the landlord because of Beggarmaster, but Ibrahim reveals that Beggarmaster was recently found dead.

Apparently, based on the evidence, Beggarmaster's killer was feeble but got lucky, because Beggarmaster's big bag of coins pinned his hand down after he fell. Ibrahim reveals that the killer shouted that he was Monkey-man, and he killed Beggarmaster for revenge. Dina turns pale and reveals that she may have accidentally helped Monkey-man plan the murder. Ibrahim tells her not to blame herself. He says her bigger concern is that without Beggarmaster, the landlord will soon send someone to throw her out.

Ibrahim tells Dina to go find a lawyer and seek an injunction against the landlord. Dina writes down notes about what to do, then leaves immediately. The courthouse is abuzz with activity. Dina thinks it's a special occasion before realizing it's just a typical workday. She stops by a board about Rent Act disputes, and all of a sudden, a whole crowd of lawyers swarms her. She is overwhelmed and tries to bat them away until they leave.

Dina sees a man sitting calmly on a bench near a sign that reveals he's a lawyer named Vasantrao Valmik. Mr. Valmik apologizes for how aggressively the other lawyers greeted Dina. He invites her to sit by him. He can't raise his voice because he has a throat issue that would cause him to lose his voice if he shouted. Mr. Valmik says that the law profession has become a joke ever since the Supreme Court made Prime Minister's illegal actions legal.

Dina explains to Mr. Valmik why she needs a lawyer. Mr. Valmik admits that she has a difficult problem, particularly in a time when goondas are often the ones in power. Still, he says he'll take the case for whatever Dina can afford to pay. For 25 years, Mr. Valmik mostly worked with the written word, but recent times forced him to get into writing speeches and slogans. This career ended after the Emergency caused the government to crack down on political organizing. Mr. Valmik leaves to work on Dina's case.

Ibrahim's decision to listen to his conscience leads to him losing his job with the landlord. His plight shows the challenges of trying to live morally in the city, where earning a living often involves making moral compromises. Meanwhile, the death of Beggarmaster shows how precarious it is to live in a society where corruption and social connections rule instead of laws.



The fact that Beggarmaster died due to the large bag of coins pinning down his hand is a clear symbol of how greed was Beggarmaster's downfall—and his efforts to seemingly reform himself at the end were too little, too late. The violence that Beggarmaster caused (both by having his beggars undergo "procedures" and by using violence to support people under his protection) ultimately turned against him.



Although Dina theoretically has legal options, she finds that actually getting the law to work for her is more complicated. The swarm of lawyers who try to win her over suggest that even people who work on the right side of the law have their own agendas and their own motivation to try to earn a profit.



Just as Mr. Valmik was a calming presence to Maneck during his journey to college, he helps Dina find solace amid the pandemonium of the other lawyers. Valmik represents one of the last voices of reason in a society that now values shouting more than carefully chosen words (a world that Valmik struggles to adapt to with his sore throat).



Valmik draws a parallel between how the British used to run India and how the goondas currently run it, with both using force to hold on to power. His status as an expert in words shows how the Emergency has led to the censorship of free speech in the country, leaving reasonable people like him in a minority compared to the shouting lawyers who surrounded Dina earlier.



Sergeant Kesar and two goondas with broken fingers show up at Dina's house to evict her. She tells them she's filed for a court injunction, but they say they arrived first, so it doesn't matter. Reluctantly, Dina opens the padlock on her door. Sergeant Kesar doesn't let the goondas inside and says that he regrets he can't help Dina, but he has a family to feed.

The return of the goondas after Beggarmaster's death reflects how, despite Dina's best efforts to use the law in her favor, ultimately violence (or at least the threat of it) holds more power in the corrupt city that she lives in. Like Ibrahim, Sergeant Kesar reveals doubts about the work he does, but unlike Ibrahim, he seems unwilling to risk his livelihood to follow his conscience.



Nusswan is shocked when Dina calls to say she's been evicted. He sends a truck to help her take her things off the pavement. She wants to just trash the belongings on the verandah, but Sergeant Kesar informs her that instead it would become the property of the landlord. The two goondas go to inspect the property there and find a trunk full of hair, including the hair of the two murdered beggars. Suddenly, Sergeant Kesar arrests the two goondas for murder.

Sergeant Kesar's decision to arrest the goondas gives him a way to follow his conscience while also working within the expectations of his job. Although he doesn't stop the eviction, he saves Dina from being implicated in a murder, suggesting that despite his previous cruelty toward the slum residents, he still has his own sense of morality. Perhaps Dina's higher social status helps him better recognize her humanity.



Sergeant Kesar explains to Dina that he knows the two goondas probably didn't commit the murder, but they're guilty of other crimes, and the Emergency makes evidence less important anyway. He imagines himself giving justice outside the law, like Dirty Harry. Nusswan's men arrive to load up Dina's possessions. Dina goes back to Nusswan's where both he and Ruby are glad to see her again.

Dirty Harry is a famous Clint Eastwood film character who operates outside the law to dispense vigilante justice. Sergeant Kesar compares himself to Dirty Harry to suggest that even though he's acting outside the law, he does the just thing, although his earlier actions clearing the slums raise the question of whether Sergeant Kesar is being honest with himself or just delusional.



That night, Dina covers herself in bed with her **quilt**. She retells the stories that each patch in the quilt reminds her of. Nusswan and Ruby worry that Dina doesn't seem as spirited as she used to be. Dina reluctantly starts doing chores around the house. On Sunday, they all play cards. Dina takes a chance in Rummy by throwing away the knave of hearts, but it fails and allows Nusswan to get Rummy. It's Dina's turn to deal next.

Rummy is a card game with popular variations worldwide that is about collecting similar cards, making the game in some ways similar to Dina's process of collecting different scraps to make a quilt. When Dina takes a chance by throwing away the knave of hearts, it represents how she took a chance by opening her heart to Maneck, Ishvar, and Omprakash and how things ultimately didn't go in her favor. But the chapter ends with Dina getting a new chance to deal, suggesting that in spite of her setbacks, she still has new opportunities.



EPILOGUE

In 1984, Maneck arrives home on a plane in the morning. Shortly after getting off the plane, he learns that there's rioting going on nearby, and the taxi drivers refuse to go toward it. Maneck eventually offers to pay double to one taxi driver, saying he needs to rush to get to Farokh's funeral. On the drive over, the driver advises Maneck to shave so that he doesn't get mistaken for a Sikh. Sikhs are a religious minority who have become the targets of massacres across the country.

Maneck has heard that Sikh bodyguards assassinated Prime Minister three days ago, but he wasn't aware of the riots against Sikhs that have followed. Maneck has been out of the country for eight years. The driver explains that because Prime Minister was unpopular, the riots are often started by criminal gangs paid by her party. As the taxi goes into the city, the driver reveals that in fact he is a Sikh who recently shaved his beard and hair.

Aban weeps when Maneck finally arrives. They sit on the porch and discuss funeral arrangements for Farokh. Maneck thought of his parents often while living in Dubai. The day of the cremation comes, and afterwards Maneck and Aban go to scatter Farokh's ashes on a mountainside around one of his favorite spots to walk.

Later, Maneck waits until Aban is napping in bed, then goes down to the empty family shop. Demand for Kohlah's Cola is mostly gone. Maneck finds a lot of old newspapers that Farokh used for packing things and starts reading them. He reads a bit about how Prime Minister was out of office for a while but came back. He then finds one about Avinash and how he seems to have died in police custody.

It starts to rain heavily. Aban wakes up and comes to the porch, where she waits for Maneck to get back. Aban says Farokh also would sometimes take walks in the rain. Maneck announces that he's going to go visit the other Sodawallas and Dina, then return to Dubai from there. Aban is hurt, but Maneck reveals that he's only going back to quit, so that he can come home and run the shop. He wants to modernize the old store.

Indira Gandhi, the inspiration for Prime Minister, had a gap between her terms in office, and so it's fitting that the novel skips several years, including the ones when she wasn't in power. Her assassination—and the massacres of Sikhs that followed—are real events from Indian history. This novel frames the riots in a way that deliberately echoes the religious tensions between Hindus and Muslims that occurred during Ishvar and Narayan's childhood, suggesting that the country is caught in a loop of violence it can't escape.



Just as during the earlier riots, the religious tensions and violence reveal the dark side of society but also present an opportunity for people of different backgrounds to come together. The fact that a Sikh man, whose own life is in danger, is the only one willing to help Maneck get to the funeral shows how human decency and selflessness can exist even in times of societal danger and turmoil.



The death of Farokh and the scattering of his ashes to the mountainside where he once walked seems to represent the end of an era, much as Prime Minister's assassination does. Although Maneck misses his home while in Dubai, in many ways, the home that he longs for no longer exists due to all the changes that have happened while he was gone.



The empty family shop echoes the death of Farokh and truly represents the end of the type of small-town success that propelled Kohlah's Cola to local fame. The information that Maneck reads in the newspapers, while distressing, could also hint at the erosion of the censorship practices that became common during the Emergency.



Maneck's decision to try to modernize the store could be yet another attempt in the novel to try to bring back a past that is gone for good. Still, the way that Maneck's walk in the rain makes his behavior like Farokh's also hints at how some things endure across generations. Maneck's dissatisfaction with his job in Dubai suggests that money alone is not enough to satisfy a person.



Maneck heads off to the city, dreading the time he'll have to spend with the Sodawallas first. He leaves after a short period of time and goes to Dina's house, which has been renovated into luxury apartments. Maneck is disappointed but finds a telephone directory to look up Nusswan.

Along the way to Nusswan, Maneck comes across a crowd who have gathered to see a holy man named Bal Baba who just returned after many years meditating in a Himalayan cave and who now accepts donations for his foundation. When Maneck goes to see "Bal Baba," he realizes that it's actually Rajaram. Maneck questions him and learns that he's selling a special tonic to grow hair. Rajaram hasn't seen Omprakash or Ishvar recently, so Maneck leaves him.

On the way out, Maneck happens to see Vasantrya Valmiki, who doesn't recognize Maneck at first with a beard. Mr. Valmiki says he enjoyed talking to Maneck the first time and would like to hear the full version of his life story at some point. Currently, Mr. Valmiki is in charge of Rajaram's mail-order business as Bal Baba.

Maneck goes to see Dina, who looks thin and old compared to the last time he saw her. She also doesn't recognize him at first with a beard. Dina says that Omprakash and Ishvar have become beggars. Ishvar now has no legs, and Omprakash has gained weight as a side effect of castration. Dina says he could meet them himself if he stays around until one, but Maneck insists that he must leave.

Before Maneck leaves, Dina shows him Avinash's chess set, which he left behind. He thanks her for the chess box and then leaves. As he's walking the streets by her house, he sees Ishvar and Omprakash headed toward him. They don't recognize Maneck and just ask for money. Maneck sees that in the gaadi Ishvar sits on, Dina's **quilt** acts as a cushion. Maneck wants to call out to them after they pass, but in the end, he doesn't.

Although it might seem like an upgrade to find luxury apartments in the place that used to hold Dina's modest home, for Maneck, this is just a sign of the city's widening wealth gap, as middle- and lower-class housing only becomes scarcer.



Rajaram's conversion from a wanted murderer into a revered holy man is yet another element of the story that criticizes religion, showing how some supposedly pious men are little more than frauds. Rajaram's promise—that his tonic can grow hair—shows that he has found success by promising an impossible thing that he knows people want. Bal Baba is a humorous name that means something like "Hair Father" or "Hair Guru" in Hindi.



The poet Valmiki recounted the life of the epic hero Rama at great length, but the more practical Mr. Valmiki takes an interest in telling the whole life story of the more down-to-earth Maneck. Mr. Valmiki's belief that even ordinary people have interesting life stories is at the foundation of the whole novel, and it reflects a generosity that contrasts with the selfishness of many in the city and the self-mythologizing of people like Rajaram as Bal Baba.



Going to visit Dina, Maneck sees only the negative qualities and how time has taken its toll on her. He does not see the positive aspects of her, like how she has managed to survive losing her home and how she has managed to stay in touch with Ishvar and Omprakash in spite of all the difficulties she faces.



As with Dina, Maneck sees only the negative qualities of Ishvar and Omprakash as he passes them, including how the years and their various medical conditions have taken a toll on them. He does not see the strength that has allowed them to survive as beggars, or how Dina's quilt represents that they still have someone who cares for them, even if the larger world seems indifferent to their survival.



Maneck goes to the Vishram Vegetarian Hotel. He orders a coffee. The waiter notices Maneck's chess set and says his son also plays the game but doesn't own a set. Maneck stays at a table until after the lunch hours have ended and the kitchen is closed. Maneck almost leaves behind his wallet and chess set at the Vishram, but the waiter points out that he's forgotten them.

Although this passage portrays Maneck's decision to leave behind the wallet and chess set as a moment of forgetfulness, it could also be the behavior of someone who is feeling suicidal. Maneck seems to consider leaving the chess set with the waiter, who would make good use of it as a gift to his son, but after his many years out of the country, Maneck struggles to relate to people at Vishram like he used to.



Maneck goes to the nearest train station. An express train that's not stopping is about to go through the station. Maneck steps onto the tracks, and his last thought is that he still has Avinash's chess set.

Maneck's suicide, while partly mysterious, seems to be related to his feelings of disconnection from his home, including the idea that the family and friends he once had are no longer around. The chess set once again seems to represent futility—that like chess, Maneck's life was a game that he couldn't win (or at least that he felt he couldn't win).



Omprakash and Ishvar come over, and Dina feeds them. She's done this for years without Nusswan or Ruby noticing. She tells them she just saw Maneck, and Ishvar says they did too, but Maneck either didn't recognize them or ignored them. Ishvar notices that a thread in his **quilt** has started to unravel. Dina gives him some thread he can use to fix it.

The unraveling of the thread in Dina's quilt represents the death of Maneck, who was part of the community at Dina's house that the quilt used to stand for. Still, Dina provides thread to fix this unraveling, suggesting that for the three of them, there is still hope of finding solidarity and solace with each other.



Omprakash and Ishvar leave in order to get away before Ruby comes back, joking with each other as they go but stopping once they get to the street. Dina shuts the door, thinking of how those two make her laugh and how Maneck once did too. She washes the plates they used, then decides to take a nap before working on making the evening meal.

Despite the many sad events of the novel and the lack of a major triumph for the characters, the final passage still celebrates their resilience. Ishvar and Omprakash still find ways to laugh with each other, even though their lives as beggars are no laughing matter. Dina's washing of the dishes shows how she has to keep her life with Ishvar and Omprakash secret, suggesting that the mainstream Indian society that Nusswan and Ruby represent still has not accepted the worth of poor but resilient people like Ishvar and Omprakash.





HOW TO CITE

To cite this LitChart:

MLA

Gahr, Tim. "A Fine Balance." *LitCharts*. LitCharts LLC, 8 May 2024. Web. 8 May 2024.

CHICAGO MANUAL

Gahr, Tim. "A Fine Balance." LitCharts LLC, May 8, 2024. Retrieved May 8, 2024. <https://www.litcharts.com/lit/a-fine-balance>.

To cite any of the quotes from *A Fine Balance* covered in the Quotes section of this LitChart:

MLA

Mistry, Rohinton. *A Fine Balance*. Vintage. 1997.

CHICAGO MANUAL

Mistry, Rohinton. *A Fine Balance*. New York: Vintage. 1997.